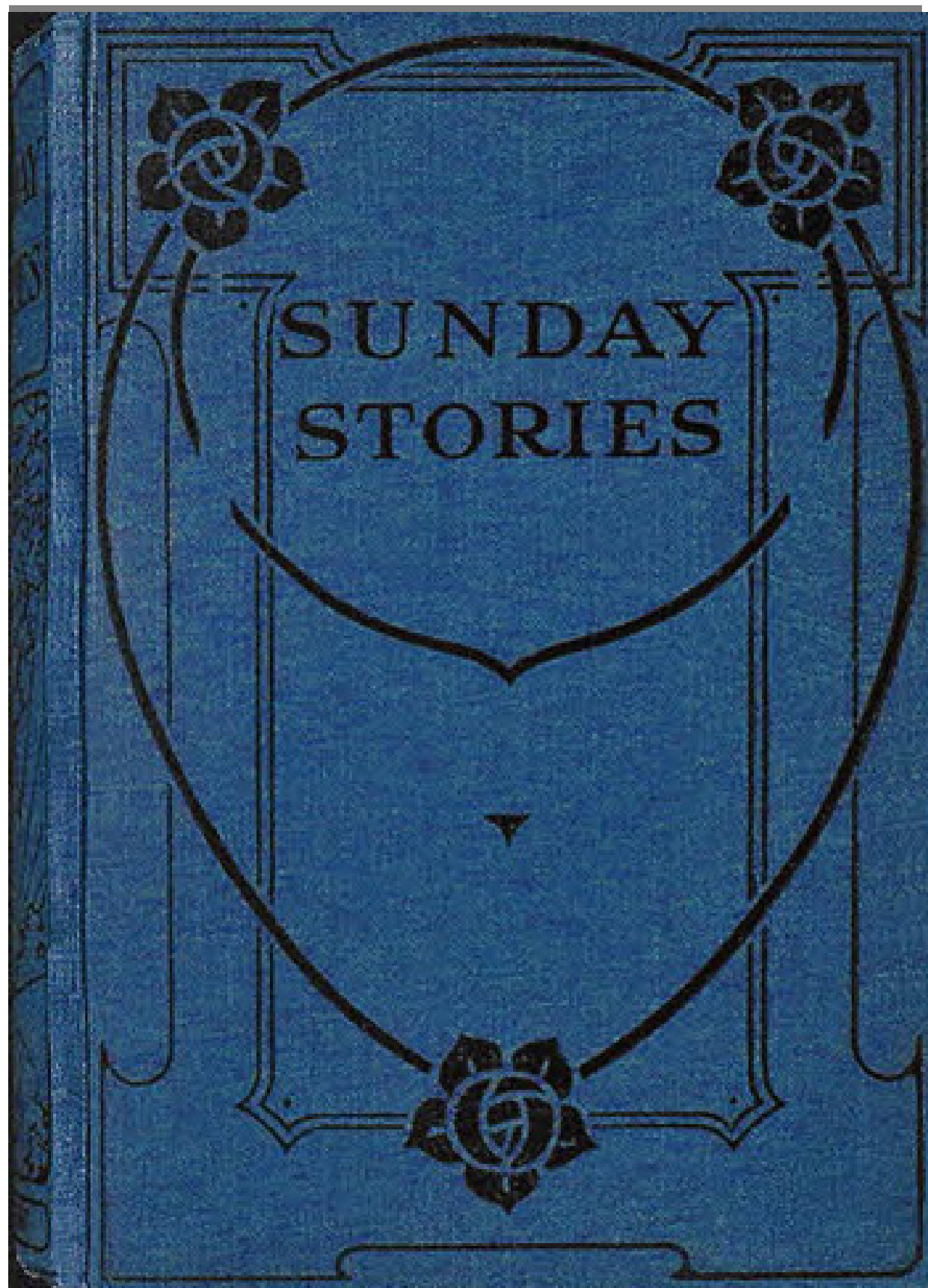


SUNDAY
STORIES



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STORIES ***

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THE FLIGHT INTO EGYPT.

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SUNDAY STORIES

STORIES FROM THE OLD AND NEW TESTAMENTS

By

CATHARINE SHAW

Author of

"Cherry's Choice," "Mother's Bible Stories,"
"Suffer Little Children," etc., etc.

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SUNDAY STORIES

I. The Message to the Shepherds

In the dark night, all was still and quiet in those fields at Bethlehem, where the shepherds watched their flock and gazed up into the starry sky, waiting for the dawn.

But as they looked, suddenly they saw an angel of the Lord close to them, and a wonderful light shone all round them—such a glory as they had never seen before, even in the brightest day.

The shepherds were very frightened, but the angel spoke to them at once; and he said to them, what God says to us so many times in the Bible: "Fear not!"

You may think how anxiously the shepherds listened to the angel's words; and those words have been repeated thousands and thousands of times all over the world, and have made heavy hearts rejoice.

Listen to the angel's message: "Fear not! for, behold, I bring you good tidings of great joy, which shall be to all people."

Still the shepherds held their breath to listen, and still the glory of the Lord shone round them.

Was that all the message? What were the glad tidings which would make everybody joyful?

Ah! Here it is: "For unto you is born this day in the city of David a Saviour, which is Christ the Lord!"

Did the shepherds turn and look eagerly towards the little village over the fields? "A Saviour? Christ the Lord?"

But hush! The angel has not finished his message: "And this shall be a sign unto you: Ye shall find the Babe wrapped in swaddling clothes, lying in a manger."

And then, as if the news was too great and too glad for them to keep silence any longer, suddenly there was with the angel thousands more angels, a multitude of the heavenly host, praising God, and saying, "Glory to God in the highest, and on earth peace, good will towards men!"

Then all the angels went back to heaven, and the shepherds said to each other, "Let us go, and see this thing that has come to pass, which the Lord hath made known to us."

So they ran very quickly to Bethlehem, and there, in the stable of the inn, they found Mary and Joseph, with the Holy Babe wrapped in

swaddling clothes, and lying in the manger!

Then the shepherds understood what the angel had meant about the "sign"; that this little Babe was the One they were looking for, and was to be the Saviour of the world.

How glad they were! They were only poor men, those shepherds, among the poorest in the land, but they had the honour of being told of God's great gift, and they had seen Him with their own eyes.

No wonder that they went out and told everybody they met that the Babe lying in the manger was Christ the Lord.

II. "His Star"

How happy those men look! They are pointing to a bright star, and it is one which they are very glad to see.

They have come a very long journey; and they have had to go through hot deserts where there is no water to be had.

What made them take that journey, do you think?

When people go a long way, they generally want to see some one at the end of it. And these wise men from the East wanted to see some one too.

They had come all that way to see a King! When they reached the end of their journey and got to Jerusalem, their first question was, "Where is He that is born King of the Jews? for we have seen His star in the East, and are come to worship Him."

Now Herod was the king of the Jews at that time, a king set up by the Romans; and when he heard what the wise men said, he did not like it at all.

So he inquired of the chief priests whether they knew where Christ should be born; and when he understood that God had said in the Scriptures that He should be born in Bethlehem, he sent secretly for the wise men, and told them to search for the Baby King, and when they had found Him, to let him know, and he would come and worship Him too.

So the wise men left King Herod, and when they began their journey again, lo! The star which they had seen in the East, went before them, till it came and stood over where the young child was.

When they saw the star, they rejoiced with exceeding great joy.

And when they were come into the house, they saw the dear little Baby with Mary His mother, and they fell down and worshipped Him; and when they had opened their treasures—which you know the camels had brought all that way—they presented to the dear Lord Jesus gifts from their store, gold, and frankincense, and myrrh.

Then God warned them in a dream to go back to their country another way, and not to return to Herod, who was a wicked man, and did not really want to worship the Lord Jesus at all.

Do you not think you would have liked to be with the wise men, and have found the dear little Baby, and have had the joy of giving Him gifts from your treasures?

If you say "Yes," dear children, then remember that you have a treasure which the dear Lord Jesus wants above all else—that is, the love of your heart! Do not forget that we can make Jesus glad now, by giving Him that!

III. The Flight into Egypt

I have told you about the wise men who saw the star of Jesus in the East, and how King Herod heard of it and was very troubled.

Herod was afraid that if the real King whom the godly Jews were expecting to come very soon should be born, he would lose his throne; so he sent for the chief priests and scribes, who knew more about the Scriptures than any one else, and asked them where Christ should be born.

They told him at once that in the book of the prophet Micah it was foretold, 700 years before, that the Ruler of Israel should be born at Bethlehem in the land of Judah.

So Herod sent the wise men to find the young Child, promising to come and worship Him too.

But the wise men were warned by God not to go back to Herod after they had seen the Lord Jesus.

Then Herod was so angry that he sent to Bethlehem and killed all the little baby boys he could find.

But God had taken care of the Lord Jesus, and before Herod's soldiers could get to Bethlehem, He was far away!

For God had spoken to Joseph in a dream, and had told him to take the little Babe, and Mary His mother, right away down into Egypt, and to stay there till He sent him word.

Joseph was a very good man, and obeyed God in all things.

When the Angel told him to go down into Egypt, he arose at once, and set out in the night with Mary and the Babe on their journey.

By and by, when the wicked King Herod was dead, God sent an angel again to Joseph, and told him to take the little Child and His mother back to Palestine, directing him to go to Nazareth, so that the words of the prophet might be fulfilled: "He shall be called a Nazarene."

So Joseph and Mary left Egypt and came back to Nazareth, "that it might be fulfilled which was spoken of the Lord by the prophet, saying, Out of Egypt have I called my Son."

We must never forget, children, that Jesus is the Son of God! He became a little child, and lived on earth as a man, in order that He might die for us; but after His death on the cross, He rose from the grave, and went back to heaven, and there He is now, ready to help us at any moment when we speak to Him. He is alive for evermore!

Nazareth was not a very good place, but the Holy Child Jesus was brought up there for thirty years. He, who did no sin and was pure and good, lived in the midst of sinful people, so that He might be a holy pattern to all of us—showing that we may be good with God's help wherever we are!

IV. Found in the Temple

It is nice to think that the dear Lord Jesus was a boy, just the age that you little boys and girls are to-day.

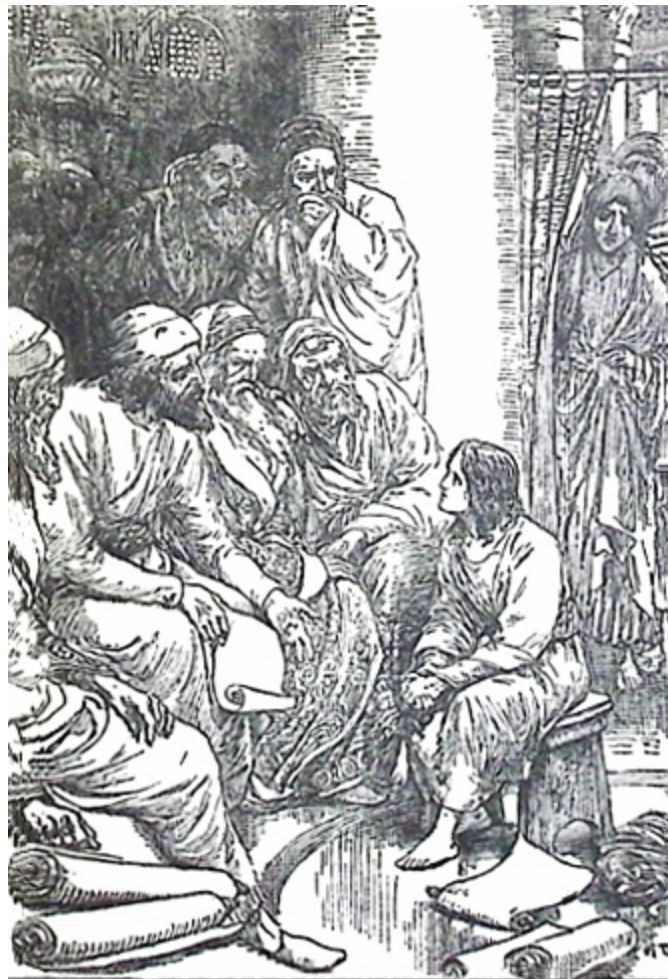
And in His holy and blameless life, while He lived on this earth, we have the great Example of how we ought to live too.

The Jews went up to Jerusalem to worship at the Passover Feast every year, and when Jesus was twelve years old, Joseph went up to worship as other Jewish men did, and the mother of Jesus went too.

A number of other people from the country villages travelled together, so that there was a very large company.

When they all set out to go home again, Jesus stayed behind in Jerusalem, and His mother and Joseph went a day's journey before they found out that He was not with the rest of the travellers.

But when they could not find Him, they turned back again to Jerusalem, and looked for Him for three whole days.



LISTENING TO THE LEARNED MEN AND ASKING THEM QUESTIONS.

LISTENING TO THE LEARNED MEN AND ASKING THEM QUESTIONS.

At length, they found Him in the Temple of God, listening to the learned men and asking them questions. And all that heard Him were astonished at His understanding and His answers.

Then His mother told Him how she and Joseph had looked for Him so long. And He gave them that gentle answer which, from the Son of God and the Son of man as He was, meant so much, "How is it that you looked for Me? Did you not know that I must be about My Father's business?"

He was speaking of His Heavenly Father, and of the glorious and loving work which He had come on earth to do.

His mother Mary thought a great deal about His sayings, and though she could not fully understand all that was going to happen, she watched her gentle Son with ever-increasing wonder and love, as she saw His obedience and wisdom, and how He grew towards manhood, loved and praised by all who knew Him.

To all children, just growing out of children into boys and girls, our blessed Lord's obedience comes as a great encouragement.

The Bible says He was "subject" to His parents; that means that He was always ready to obey in His earthly home, and to live a quiet life in a carpenter's shop in the lowly town of Nazareth!

V. At Jordan

John the Baptist had been sent by God to baptize the people for the remission of sins, and to tell them that the Lamb of God who was to "take away the sin of the world" was soon coming to live among them, and to be their Saviour.

"And it came to pass in those days, that Jesus came from Nazareth . . . and was baptized of John in Jordan."

"And straightway coming up out of the water, He saw the heavens opened, and the Spirit like a dove descending upon Him; and there came a voice from heaven, saying, 'Thou art My beloved Son, in whom I am well pleased.'"

"And John saw, and bare record, that this is the Son of God."

So now we know, children, what was happening all those eighteen years at Nazareth, while Jesus grew from a boy into a man.

The people at Nazareth were offended at Him, when, after His baptism, He began to go about the country healing the sick, and teaching the people about God; and they said, scornfully, "Is not this the Carpenter?"

But God gives us the whole history of those eighteen quiet years in one sentence—

"This is My beloved Son in whom I am well pleased!"

— When John saw Jesus coming to him to be baptized, he had exclaimed,

"Behold the Lamb of God, which taketh away the sin of the world!"

And two of his disciples, hearing him speak, turned and followed Jesus.

May we hear those blessed words, and follow Him too!

VI. "Nazareth where He was brought up"

When the Lord Jesus was on earth, He lived among men for thirty-three and a half years.

We have in the New Testament only little glimpses of His life during the first thirty years.

First as a little baby; then, as a boy of twelve, we see Him journeying to Jerusalem to be present at the Passover Feast, and we are told that when He returned home to Nazareth He "was subject" to His mother and Joseph, and obedient to them in all things.



FOUND IN THE TEMPLE.

Here for eighteen quiet years Jesus lived learning the trade of a carpenter, and working with His own blessed hands, making the simple things that were used by the country people around Him—seats, and tables, ploughs, and yokes for oxen.

Is it not nice to think that Jesus knows all about making yokes!

Do you not remember afterwards, how He said, "Take My yoke upon you, and learn of ME . . . for My yoke is easy, and My burden is light"?

So children, Jesus knows exactly all about the weight of "the yoke" you may have to bear. Everybody has some trial or burden; but Jesus says,

if you will come to Him, the yoke He has made for you will be light.

I like to think that when He made yokes for the oxen, He made them as comfortable and easy and light as they could possibly be made, so that no rough edge should gall the patient animal as he pulled the heavy plough!

When Jesus was thirty years old, all the wonderful things began which we read of in the Gospels.

His first public appearance was when He came to John the Baptist to be baptized by him in the river Jordan, which we shall read about on the next page.

Soon after this He began His public ministry.

One Sabbath day, He went to the synagogue as was His custom, and stood up to read from the Holy Book.

The servant or attendant gave Him a roll of the Prophet Isaiah, and, when He had found the place, He began to read.

And what do you think the Son of God, the Saviour of the World, read to explain His great mission?

He read: "The Lord . . . hath anointed Me to preach good tidings to the poor; He hath sent Me to heal the brokenhearted; to preach deliverance to the captives, and recovering of sight to the blind; to set at liberty them that are bruised."

He comes to each one of us first of all with the promise of forgiveness. His name means that!

"Jesus: for He shall save His people from their sins."

VII. The Well at Nazareth

In the story belonging to the last picture, we heard how God sent an angel to Joseph in a dream, and told him to take the Lord Jesus and His mother away from Egypt, and to go back to their own city, Nazareth.

Our next picture is of the public well at Nazareth, where people even to this very day go to draw all the water which they want.

For you know, children, that water is not "laid on" in eastern countries, but has to be fetched from long distances in jars or skins.

The women and children generally do this; and the Lord Jesus when He was a little boy must have gone daily to this well with His mother, keeping her company in the long hot walks to and fro, and helping her to carry the jars of water back to their home.

If you were to go to Palestine, the land where Jesus lived, you would see (besides, the women who come to the wells) the water-carriers, who have large pig-skins supported by straps to their shoulders.

These they fill with water, and tie up the neck securely with a string; and then they carry the heavy skin to the next town or village; and as they go along they call out—

"Ho! Thirsty ones, come and buy water! Here is water! Do you want to buy it?"

Then the people who have any money to spare, and who do not want to walk the long distance to the well, come out to the water-carriers and have their jars filled and pay for it.

Do you remember what God says about that in the 55th chapter of Isaiah?

"Ho! Every one that thirsteth, come ye to the waters, and he that hath no money come and buy. Yea, come and buy wine and milk without money and without price."

Ah, children, God gives us His gifts without money and without price! The "Living Water" which Jesus promises, we have only to ask of Him and we shall be given it.

For Jesus is the Living Water Himself, and those who drink of that water and have Jesus in their hearts, will find that He makes them happy, and that having Him for their Saviour they have all they need!

We read of many wells in the Bible, and some of them are to be found now.

There is "Jacob's Well," where Jesus promised the Living Water to the woman of Samaria; and there is this well at Nazareth, which is called "Mary's Well" now, because people feel sure that Mary, the dear mother of Jesus, must have drawn water at it when she lived at Nazareth.

It is nice to think that the feet of Jesus as a little child walked along those roads; that His eyes rested on those very hills that surround Nazareth; that He picked some of the countless flowers that grow all over the fields and make a carpet of beautiful colours such as we never see here.

This was the home of Jesus all the time He was a child; and here He lived every day, and watched Joseph at his work in his carpenter's shop. It was here that He lived an obedient, dutiful life, and grew in favour with God and with men. It was here He pleased His Heavenly Father in all things.

It is a nice thought, children, that whatever age you are, He was just that age too; so that He knows what children's feelings are, and all their little trials or joys or temptations.

He lives in heaven now, it is true, but He is ready to help you if you look up to Him.

I do not mean looking up with your eyes, but with your heart and your thoughts.

Just a little word or two spoken in Your heart will bring help from Jesus!

A little prayer of three words has made many a person happy when he was miserable before.

"Lord help me!" or "Lord save me!" will bring Jesus near in a moment; and He does help and save!

VIII. At Bethany

There seems to have been one home especially where the Lord Jesus loved to visit.

We hear a great deal about the people who lived in this home, perhaps more about them than any other of the friends of Jesus.

Their names were Lazarus, Martha and Mary.

One day the Lord Jesus was going about healing the sick, and teaching people about His Heavenly Father, and in His journey He came to the village of Bethany, where Martha and Mary and Lazarus lived.

Martha was a very industrious, energetic woman, and when she saw Jesus and His disciples coming, I dare say she ran out to meet them, and invited them into her house to have something to eat.

She bustled about and spread the table; she told her servants what to bring to set before the large company who had suddenly come to her; and

with joyful willingness she hurried to put before them whatever she could think of to make them welcome.

Suddenly her eyes fell upon her only sister, Mary. She was not bustling about and getting the dinner ready; she was sitting near Jesus, eagerly listening to His words, and satisfied to be in His presence.

Poor Martha! She loved to hurry about and make Jesus welcome, but to have her sister sit idle and enjoy to hear Him talk, was more than she could bear.

So she got quite cross and vexed. She felt that it was too hard; and she ran to Jesus and asked Him how it was He did not care that Mary had left her all the work to do alone, and begged Him to bid Mary come and help her.

And then Jesus turned to her and said those gentle words which have been a lesson to busy, bustling people all these hundreds of years: "Martha, Martha, you are too much troubled over these many things; only one thing is needful, and Mary has chosen the good part which shall never be taken away from her."



SHE WAS NEAR JESUS, EAGERLY LISTENING

SHE WAS NEAR JESUS, EAGERLY LISTENING.

Do you ask, children, what that one thing is?

It is learning of Jesus, and hearing His voice.

Even if everything else is lost to us, if we have Jesus we can be happy. Even the poorest and most wretched person in the world, who has heard the voice of Jesus, has the "one thing" which will make him happy here, and will give him endless joy by and by.

IX. The Temptation

Directly after the Lord Jesus had been baptized, and God had spoken out of heaven saying He was His beloved Son, the Holy Spirit led Jesus into the wilderness to be tempted by Satan.

Perhaps you ask, dear children, "Why must Jesus, the Holy One, be tempted by Satan?"

I think it was for two reasons: that He might be our perfect example in everything; and that He might show us the way to conquer Satan.

It says in the Bible Jesus was tempted in all points like we are!

One of Satan's temptations to Jesus in the wilderness was "if He was the Son of God," to make the stones into bread.

Jesus was very hungry, He had not had food for a long time; but Jesus would not do what Satan asked Him. He said to Satan, that it was written in God's word "that men were not to live by bread alone," but to please God first of all.

You will understand His wonderful answers to Satan's temptations as you get older. But you can remember this now—If Satan tells you to do wrong, tell him boldly in return, that "Jesus is your Saviour, and He died to save you."

It says in the Bible, "His name shall be called Jesus, for He shall save His people from their sins," and if you say to Satan the one word "Jesus!" you will find that he runs away.

X. The Deep Well

Jesus was taking a long journey. He had to walk many, many miles, and at last, when He came near a large town called Samaria, He sent His disciples on in front to buy food.

He was very tired, and while He waited for them, He sat down to rest by the well which, hundreds of years before, Jacob had dug, which has been called ever since Jacob's Well.

Presently a woman from the town came with her pitcher to draw some water. As it was twelve o'clock in the day, the sun Was very hot, and the dear Lord Jesus was very thirsty.

When the woman came close to the well, He asked her to give Him some water to drink. But she was so busy with her own thoughts, that she told Him she was surprised that He should ask her for anything, as the Jews were not friendly with the people of Samaria.

Jesus did not answer that; for His loving heart knew all about her, and how she needed a Saviour to save her from her sins.

So He said to her something like this—

"If you knew what a wonderful gift God has to give you, and Who it is that has asked you to give Him drink, you would have asked Him instead, and He would have given you living water."

The woman could not understand this at all. She saw that Jesus had nothing to draw with, and she knew that Jacob's Well was very deep. What could He mean by living water?

Then Jesus told her that if any one came to Him for this living water, he would never be thirsty again, but would have everlasting life!

The woman began to think that it would be very nice not to be thirsty any more, so she asked Jesus to give her this water; but she did not know that she was talking to the Son of God, Who gives the Holy Spirit; she only thought of her many hot journeys to and from the well.

And now the Lord has to show her that it is something much better than real water that He wants her to have. He explains to her that she is a sinner, and He tells her so much about her past life, which she thought nobody knew, that she begins to guess that Jesus must be the Christ whom the Jews were expecting to come into the world.

Then Jesus said, "I, that speak unto thee, am He."

The woman was so surprised, and so glad, that she left her waterpot and ran back to the town to tell her neighbours all about her wonderful Saviour.

So numbers of them came out to find Jesus, and many believed on Him, not only because the woman had said that Jesus had told her all that ever she did, but because they heard from His own loving lips the words which brought them everlasting life.

XI. "Suffer Little Children to come unto Me"

A number of people are pressing round the dear Lord Jesus!

The mothers have heard how kind He is, and how He is doing good to everybody who comes to Him, and they are anxious that their little ones shall be blessed too.

So they take their babes in their arms, and their toddling children by the hand, and lead them to where they know the Lord Jesus is.

When the little ones see His loving face, they are not a bit afraid. They run to Him, sure that He will not refuse them, and when they come to Him, Jesus takes them up in His arms, puts His hands upon them, and blesses them.

The men who are following the dear Lord Jesus, think that the little children will be a trouble to Him, so they tell the mothers to take the little ones away; but we read that Jesus was much displeased, and said, "Suffer little children to come unto Me, and forbid them not; for of such is the kingdom of heaven."

Yes, Jesus said, when He was here walking about in our world, "Let the children come unto Me, and do not forbid them"; and now He is gone to be with His Father in heaven, He says just the same to all of you little ones. "Come to Me!" He says every day.

He is here in spirit, just as much as He was then, and He wants you to love Him with all your loving little hearts.

He loves you so much that He cares about everything that happens to you. He cares whether you are happy, He is sorry if you are naughty, and He is glad when you are good. He loves to have you do anything to please Him, and His dear eyes see you all day long, and He will help you to please Him if you ask Him.

Besides all this, the Lord Jesus has died on the cross, to bear the punishment of your sins, instead of you.

Should you not think it very kind if a little brother were to offer to be punished instead of the one who had done wrong?

That is what Jesus did. He took upon Himself the sin of the whole world, that whoever trusts Him and comes to Him, may be forgiven, and may go at last to live with Him, and with God our Heavenly Father, in that bright and beautiful home which He is getting ready for all who love Him.

Perhaps you ask, "Why does Jesus want you to come to Him?"

When you have been naughty and are sorry, why does mother hold out her loving arms to you?

Is it not that you may run into there and be forgiven and comforted? Is it not because she loves you?

Does she not wipe away your tears, and tell you that she will not think of your fault any more?

Does she not take you with her about the house, or in the garden, and show you by her manner how glad she is that you have come to her for forgiveness, and that you are going to try to do better?

Well, that is just a little bit like the love of Jesus.

He wishes you to come to Him, that you may have happiness and joy.

He wants you to live with Him all day long, and walk about by His side; to go to Him in every trouble; to ask His help in anything difficult.

You cannot see Him yet, but He is close to you all the time, and He can see you and hear you in an instant when you speak to Him.

By and by He will give you endless pleasures at His right hand for evermore.

"Gentle Jesus, meek and mild,
Look upon a little child;
Pity my simplicity,
Suffer me to come to Thee.

"Fain I would to Thee be brought,
Blessed Lord, forbid it not:
In the kingdom of Thy grace
Give a little child a place."

XII. "Follow Me"

Soon after Jesus had chosen Peter and James and John as His disciples, He was walking near the lake of Gennesaret when He saw Matthew sitting at the place where the people had to pay taxes.

For Matthew was not a fisherman, like the others, but was a taxgatherer employed by the Romans to collect money from the Jews.

These taxgatherers were very much disliked, as they often took more money than they ought, and kept it for themselves, so that the Jews hated them and dreaded to see them coming.

But the Lord Jesus chooses disciples from all sorts of people. He does not wait till we are good, to call us to follow Him; but He says to us, just where we are, at school, at work, at play, in the street, in the home, in the shop, "Follow Me."

And these words mean, "Keep close to Me, where you can see Me and speak to Me. And if you keep close to Me, by and by when I lead the way into My glory in Heaven, you, if you are following Me, shall come with Me and share all I have."

So Jesus called Matthew the publican; and Matthew heard His call, and rose up, and left all and came after Jesus.

Dear children, if we hear Jesus calling us, let us leave behind anything that would displease Him, and tell Him we are ready to follow Him wherever He may lead.

XIII. Lazarus

Not so very long after the supper where Martha had served, her brother Lazarus fell sick and died.

We are told that "Jesus loved Martha and her sister and Lazarus," and yet He let him die!

Ah, how often have those whom Jesus loves, to trust Him through the very hardest thing that could happen to them!

Jesus was not there when Lazarus fell ill, and though they sent to Him to tell Him, He did not go to them at once, but stayed where He was for two more days. In the meantime Lazarus died, and was buried.

At length Jesus told His disciples that He would go to Bethany.

When they got near to where Lazarus lived, Martha heard that Jesus was coming, and hurried out to meet Him with the words, "Lord, if you had been here, my brother would not have died. But I know that whatever you ask of God, God will give it to you."

Then Jesus told her that Lazarus would rise again; and Martha showed her faith in answering that she knew he would rise at the last day. And again Jesus questioned her with these wonderful resurrection words, "Whosoever liveth and believeth in Me shall never die. Believest thou this?"

And Martha gave one of the most wonderful answers that we read in the Bible: "Yea, Lord: I believe that Thou art the Christ, the Son of God, which should come into the world."

Blessed Martha! She had found the one thing needful!

So by and by they come to Bethany, and Jesus sent for Mary to come from the house of mourning to Him.

And Mary's first words were the same as Martha's, "Lord, if you had been here, my brother had not died."

Oh, the compassion of Jesus! He knew that soon their sorrow would be turned into joy, but when He saw them all weeping. He was very troubled, and wept too.

And so they come to the grave; and Jesus told them to take away the stone. The Martha reminded Him that Lazarus had been dead four days.

But Jesus answered her, "Did I not say to you, that, if you would believe, you should see the glory of God?"

And Jesus lifted up His eyes, and said, "Father, I thank Thee that Thou hast heard Me . . . that they may believe that Thou hast sent Me."

And then He called with a loud voice, "Lazarus, come forth!" And the dead man came forth, bound with graveclothes and Jesus said to them, "Loose him, and let him go."

Oh, how happy those sisters were! Did not Martha, indeed, see the glory of God, as Jesus had said?

XIV. The Widow's Mite

One day, very shortly before our dear Lord was crucified, He was teaching in God's Temple at Jerusalem and preaching the gospel.

He had been warning the people against the scribes, who loved to seem very good and to be thought well of, who chose the highest seats in the synagogues and the chief rooms at feasts, who made long prayers for a show, and who oppressed poor widows and took away their houses.

The Lord looked straight into people's hearts, and He could not bear for the scribes to seem very good outside and to be very wicked inside!

Jesus was sitting near the treasury, which was the chest or receptacle in which the people put their offerings of money for God's service.

After He had been speaking about those scribes that oppressed the widows, He raised His eyes and saw the people casting their gifts into the treasury; and many that were rich cast in much.



JUST THEN A POOR WIDOW DREW NEAR.

JUST THEN A POOR WIDOW DREW NEAR.

And just then a poor widow drew near, and she put in two mites, which make a farthing.

Jesus saw it all! He could see into her empty pocket; He knew all about it!

Then He called His disciples to Him and said to them, "This poor widow has cast more in than all the others who have cast into the treasury: for they did cast in of their abundance; but she of her want did cast in all that she had, even all her living!"

There is another widow we read of, who gave all her living to God! The account is in 1 Kings xvii. God sent the prophet Elijah to her in a time of famine. When he got to where the widow lived, he found her gathering a few sticks to make a fire to bake the last bit of bread that she had!

So Elijah called to her to fetch him a little water. He was nearly dying of thirst, and as she ran to fetch it, he begged her also to bring him a morsel of bread too.

But she told him that she only had a tiny bit of meal left in the barrel, and a little oil in a cruse, and this she was going to make into a little cake for her and her son, and when they had eaten that, she said, they must die!

But Elijah said some words like these to her: "Fear not . . . make me a little cake first, and bring it to me . . . for thus saith the Lord God of Israel, You shall always find a little meal in the barrel, and a little oil in the cruse as long as the famine lasts!"

And she believed God's promise, and went and did as Elijah had said; and she and Elijah and her son had enough to eat for many days.

XV. "Do this in Remembrance of Me"

Very soon after this, just before the Feast of the Passover, when Jesus knew that the hour had come that He was to die, and to go back to His Father, He wished to do one last act of love to His disciples, because "He loved them to the uttermost."

And supper being ended, Jesus rose up and taking a towel He poured water into a basin, and began to wash the feet of His disciples.

This astonished them very much, and when it came to Peter's turn, he said, "Lord, dost Thou wash my feet?"

Then Jesus said to him something like this, "You cannot understand what I am doing now, Peter, but you shall understand by and by."

But Peter said to Jesus, "Thou shalt never wash my feet!"

And Jesus answered him, "If I do not wash you, Peter, you have no part with Me."

So Peter at last let Jesus wash his feet; but he asked Him to wash his hands too, and his head. I think he meant that he wanted to be made wholly clean!

Jesus is our perfect example, and though He was their Lord and Master, He did for them what was the office of the servants in the East, that they might hereafter remember that there is no act, however lowly, that they should be unwilling to perform for one of His disciples.

This loving example has helped thousands of the followers of Jesus to go into prisons and hospitals; or to minister to the sick in crowded, wretched rooms, where dirt and misery abound; that they may brighten and cleanse them, and bring a little, to the poor suffering inmates, of that love of Jesus which loves to the uttermost, and "is able to save to the uttermost, those that come unto God by Him."

* * * * *

And now the hour for the Passover Feast had come, and Jesus sat down, the twelve apostles with Him, and He told them that with a great desire He had longed to eat that Passover with them before He suffered.

Dear children, you have often heard of the Communion of the Lord's Supper, and some of you may have been with your parents, and may have seen it.

But now I am going to tell you about the first time the Lord's Supper was held.

Ever since that time for nearly nineteen hundred years, the people who love the Lord Jesus have met together "to remember Him" as He told them; and those who love Him are told to do this, till He comes back again to take us to His heavenly home.

So that night "in which He was betrayed" this was how our dear Lord gave us this last command.

"And He took bread, and gave thanks, and brake it, and gave unto them, saying, 'This is My body which is given for you: this do in remembrance of Me.'

"Likewise also the cup after supper, saying, 'This cup is the New Testament in My blood which is shed for you.'

"And when they had sung a hymn, they went out into the Mount of Olives."

And Jesus said to them, "All ye shall be offended because of Me this night: for it is written, 'I will smite the Shepherd, and the sheep shall be scattered!'"

But in His great forgiving love, though Jesus knew they would all forsake Him, He gave them the promise, that when He was risen from the dead He would go before them to Galilee, and there they should see Him again.



THE CITY ON A HILL.

THE CITY ON A HILL.

XVI. The Lame Man Leaping

Acts iii. 8

One day, very soon after the Holy Spirit had been sent down to give power to the disciples, Peter and John, as their custom was, went up into the Temple to pray.

It was what was called the ninth hour, our three o'clock in the afternoon, and was "the hour of prayer" in Jerusalem.

Peter and John climbed up the many steps that led to the Temple, and reached the gate called the Beautiful Gate.

Some one else had come up those many steps, too; but he had not walked. He had been lame all his life, and daily his friends carried him up that long way, to lay him in the Beautiful Gate.

What do you think they took all that trouble for? It was that the poor lame man might ask for money of the passersby who went up to pray.

He had no means of providing for himself, and, like many other sick and helpless people, he lay there hour after hour, holding out his hand to receive the coins which the pity of the passersby made them give him.

As he saw Peter and John about to go into the Temple, he begged them to have pity on him in his poverty.

Then Peter, knowing that within him rested the great power of God, said to the lame man, "Look on us!"

The poor man eagerly obeyed, thinking they were not going to pass on without showing him some kindness.

He was quite right. Peter at once said: "I have not any silver or gold! But what I have, I will give you! In the Name of Jesus Christ of Nazareth, rise up and walk!" And he took him by the right hand, and lifted him up, and immediately his feet and ankle bones were given strength, and the man, who had been a cripple for more than forty years, walked and leapt, and went with Peter and John into the Temple, walking and leaping and praising God!

Then all the people, who knew all about this lame man for so many years, were filled with amazement at what had happened to him. For the lame man held Peter and John, and all the people ran together into Solomon's Porch to see the wonderful sight. But Peter told them, at once,

that it was not by their own power that they had made this man well, but because God had glorified His Son Jesus, and that it was through faith in His Name that he had been given this perfect soundness.

And then he told these wondering, amazed Jews, that it was their God, "the God of Abraham and Isaac and Jacob," who had sent Jesus to earth to bless them, and to turn away every one of them from their sins.

And that blessed Name of Jesus has the same power now to help and save all who look to Him. Forgiveness, strength, comfort, and help can belong to those who will trust Him!

XVII. Gethsemane

Many, many hundreds of years ago, the Easter full moon was shining down in all its beauty on a garden near Jerusalem.

This garden was called Gethsemane and I should think that every one who loves the Lord Jesus, and who knows about His great agony in that garden, must love the very name of the place, and remember with very tender feelings all He bore for our sakes.

Every Easter now, when the moon shines so sweetly, we can recall that night on which our dear Lord was betrayed, and we can ask Him to help us to watch and pray that we may not enter into temptation.

He had just eaten the Passover Supper with His disciples; He had told them and us, to "do this, as oft as ye take it, in remembrance of ME," and then, after they had sung a hymn, or psalm, they went down the steep path from one of the gates leading out of Jerusalem, to go to the Mount of Olives.

Just at the bottom of the valley there lay the Garden of Gethsemane; and the Lord Jesus, who knew all that was going to happen to Him the next day,—how He would be mocked and beaten and crucified—wanted to pray to His Heavenly Father before He was betrayed into the hands of the Jews.

So He turned into the garden beneath the olive trees, telling some of His disciples to wait outside, but taking Peter and James and John into the garden with Him.

He was very, very sorrowful, so He bade them wait near Him and watch. Then He went a little further on, and fell on the ground and prayed to His Father that, if it were possible, the hour might pass away from Him.

He knew that all things were possible with God, but He did not want to have His own will, if His dear Father in Heaven wished anything different. He had come to earth to do His will perfectly.

Then after His prayer, He rose and went to His disciples. But he found them asleep! They had not watched as He bade them.

So He said to Peter, "Simon, sleepest thou? couldest thou not watch one hour?"

And then He told them to watch and pray lest they should enter into temptation.

He said He knew they were willing to do it, but they had tired bodies, and this made it the more necessary to be watchful.

So He went away again and prayed to His Father in an agony that the bitter cup might pass from Him.

We cannot fully understand all that is meant by that bitter cup. It is enough for us to know that our blessed Lord dreaded it above everything.

But even in the midst of that misery, He could say, "Oh, My Father, if this cup may not pass away from Me except I drink it, Thy will be done!"

And there appeared an angel from heaven, strengthening Him.

Still again a third time He went away and prayed the same prayer, but all the while His disciples were fast asleep!

At last Jesus rose up from prayer, and when He came to His disciples He told them that now He was going to be betrayed into the hands of sinners.

As He was speaking, a great band of men, led by wicked Judas, came hurrying into the garden.

Now Judas had said to the chief priests (when he sold Jesus to them for thirty pieces of silver), "Whomsoever I shall kiss, that same is He; hold Him fast."

The Lord Jesus, who is God as well as man, could easily have escaped from their cruel hands. He told them He could have prayed to His Father, and He would have sent Him thousands and thousands of angels.

The band of men and officers from the chief priests were so amazed at the majesty of Jesus, that they went backward and fell to the ground.

But Jesus was ready to die for us; for how else could we be saved?

Then they took Jesus prisoner, and bound Him and led Him away to the palace of the High Priest.

And as He was led away from Gethsemane, He said to Peter those memorable words of love and submission—"The cup which My Father hath given Me, shall I not drink it?"

He knew that the Cross to which He was going was His Father's Will! For had He not said Himself, to the people?—

"For God so loved the world, that He gave His only begotten Son, that whosoever believeth in Him should not perish, but have everlasting life."

XVIII. The Trial

When Judas had betrayed the Lord Jesus with a kiss, and the band of soldiers and officers were going to take Him away, Peter tried to defend Jesus by drawing his sword, and he smote one of the servants of the High Priest and cut off his ear.

But Jesus did not wish His disciples to fight for Him with swords, and He told Peter to put it up in the sheath again; and then, in His love and compassion, He healed the man's ear.

And Jesus said to the soldiers, "Are you come out as if I were a thief, with swords and staves to take me? I was with you every day in the Temple, teaching you, and you did not take Me; but the Scriptures must be fulfilled."

Then all His disciples forsook Him and fled.

Jesus is the Good Shepherd; and now it had come to the time when He was going to lay down His life for the sheep.

But oh! How sad it must have made Him, to have all His disciples run away from Him!

Then the soldiers bound Him and led Him away.

But after the first moment of fear and dismay, John, the beloved disciple, ran to follow his Master, and the crowd tried to prevent his going after Jesus. But he managed to escape from them, and presently he reached the High Priest's house, and, as he was known to the High Priest, he went in with Jesus into the palace.

But Peter was left in the garden, and he followed afar off, even into the palace of the High Priest, and sat with the servants and warmed himself at the fire.

When the whole band had brought Jesus into the palace, they found there all the chief priests, and the elders, and the scribes.

Then the chief priests and all the council sought for witness against Jesus to put Him to death; but found none.

There were many false witnesses who gave evidence against Him, but they all contradicted each other.

All this time Jesus stood silent, listening to their false charges, but not answering a word.

At last the High Priest exclaimed, "Answerest thou nothing? What is it that these witness against thee?"

But Jesus held His peace, and answered nothing.

Then the High Priest asked Him a question which Jesus answered.

He said, "Art Thou the Christ, the Son of the Blessed?"

And Jesus said, "I am; and ye shall see the Son of Man sitting on the right hand of power, and coming in the clouds of heaven."

Then the High Priest tore his clothes, and said there was no need to examine any more witnesses, for they had heard Him say Himself that He was the Son of God.



THEN THE HIGH PRIEST TORE HIS CLOTHES.

THEN THE HIGH PRIEST TORE HIS CLOTHES.

And for this they all condemned Him to be guilty of death.

XIX. The King of the Jews

When the chief priests of the Jews had determined to kill the Lord Jesus, after examining Him for many hours on the dreadful night when all His disciples had forsaken Him and Peter had denied Him, they consulted together as to how they could carry out their wicked plan.

The morning dawned before they had decided what to do; and at length, as they did not like to put Him to death themselves, they thought the best way would be to take Him to Pilate the Roman governor, for they thought that he would do what they wished.

The Jews and the High Priest had asked Jesus whether He was really the Christ, the Son of God; and the Lord Jesus, to leave them without excuse, told them plainly that He was, and that hereafter they would see Him sitting in heaven, and coming back to earth in the clouds.

At this they had been fearfully angry, and had torn their clothes, and had bound Him and led Him away to Pilate, in the hopes that Pilate would at once order Him to be put to death.

* * * * *

Now we are told in Matthew's Gospel that Judas, who had betrayed his Master with a kiss, saw Jesus led away to Pilate. He knew by this that the chief priests had condemned Him to death, and, too late, Judas repented of the wicked thing he had done.

Jesus had told the disciples when they sat down to the Passover supper, that one of them should betray Him, and Judas had asked, among the rest, "Lord, is it I?" And Jesus had told him, that though He must die to save the world, yet it was woe to the man who should betray Him.

But Judas thought of the thirty pieces of silver which he was going to earn for doing this sad deed, and he left the supper table and went out into the dark night.

Judas had made his decision against Jesus!

Oh, children! Let our decision be for Jesus! All through our lives, let our one purpose be that He shall be our Lord and our King. We shall not be sorry by and by that we have decided so.

But Judas had made his evil choice; he had set going a thing which he could not now stop. And when he realized that the chief priests had really condemned Jesus, Judas would have given everything he possessed to undo what he had done. But it was too late.

He hurried back to the chief priests with the money in his hand, and he exclaimed, "I have sinned; I have betrayed the innocent One!"

But they said, "What is that to us? You must see to that!"

So he threw down the thirty pieces of silver in the Temple, and went and hanged himself.

Oh, poor Judas! What good was his money to him then? "What shall it profit a man if he gain the whole world, and lose his own soul?"

Then the chief priests took up the silver and consulted as to what they should do with it, because it was "the price of blood," and they might not put it into God's Treasury; and they decided to buy a field, called the Potter's field, to bury strangers in. And that field was called "the Field of Blood" ever afterwards. We read in the Bible that, five hundred years before that, it was foretold by the prophet Zechariah that all these things should be done, when Jesus was sold for thirty pieces of silver.

* * * * *

So Jesus was brought before Pilate, and stood there in all His majesty and humility, and Pilate asked Him, "Art Thou the King of the Jews?" And Jesus again left no excuse to those who condemned Him. Though He had answered nothing when the false witnesses spoke against Him, though He answered nothing now when the chief priests and elders accused Him, yet, to give Pilate an opportunity of believing and accepting Him, He answered him at once—

"You have said what I am—a King. To this end was I born, and for this cause came I into the world, that I should bear witness of the truth."

Then Pilate told the chief priests that he found no fault in Him.

When Pilate found it impossible to quiet the chief priests, though he told them he could find no fault in Jesus, he decided to send Him to Herod, who was at Jerusalem at that time.

And when Herod saw Jesus, he was very glad, because he had heard of Him, and hoped to have seen a miracle done by Him.

So he asked Jesus a great many questions, but He answered him nothing.

And the chief priests stood and vehemently accused Him.

And Herod and his soldiers mocked Him and arrayed Him in a gorgeous robe, and sent Him again to Pilate.

Now at the feast of the Passover, the Roman governor pleased the Jews by setting free a prisoner whomsoever they asked for. So, because Pilate did not like the Jews, and knew that they had delivered Jesus up for envy, he offered to release to them Barabbas, who was a great robber, or "Jesus who was called Christ"?

So Pilate went back to the judgment-seat and sat down. And it was quite early morning yet.

Then his wife sent down in haste to him to have nothing to do with condemning Jesus, because she had had a dreadful dream, and she knew that Jesus was a just man.

But the chief priests and elders persuaded the multitude that they should ask for Barabbas.

Pilate was sure that Jesus was not worthy of any punishment; but when he found that the Jews were raising a great tumult, and that they charged Pilate with not being Cæsar's friend, if he allowed Jesus to be the King of the Jews, Pilate was afraid.

He was more afraid of the Jews than of God! And so poor Pilate made his great decision. And he, like Judas, made it on the wrong side!

So he called for water, and when it was brought to him, he washed his hands before all the people, saying, "I am innocent of the blood of this just person: see ye to it."

Then Pilate said to them, mockingly, "Shall I crucify your King?"

But they cried the more exceedingly, "Crucify Him, crucify Him!"

And the voices of them and of the chief priests prevailed.

Then Pilate released Barabbas to them, and when he had scourged Jesus, he delivered Him to be crucified.

XX. The Soldiers Mocked Him

So when Pilate had sentenced Him to be crucified the governor's soldiers took Jesus into the common hall, and gathered together the rest of the soldiers, and began to mock at the dear Lord whom we love so much.

They clothed Him with a purple robe, and they plaited a crown of long sharp thorns and put it on His loving head, and then they put a reed in His hand and bowed down to Him, and mocked Him saying, "Hail, King of the Jews!"

Jesus did not mind being called the King of the Jews, because He came on earth to be their King; He was only sorry that they would not love Him, or have Him for their King and Saviour.

Ah, how it must have cut Him to the heart in all His pain, to have them mock Him, and beat Him on the head, and spit upon Him, and pretend to worship Him.

If our hearts are filled with grief that He could have suffered so much, should we not love Him more than ever; and turn away from the sins which He died on purpose to save us from?

So Pilate went outside again, and said to the Jews, "Behold, I bring Him forth to you, that you may know that I find no fault in Him."

Then Jesus came out wearing the crown of thorns, and Pilate said, "Behold the man!"

But the Jews burst out again with the cry, "Crucify Him!"

And Pilate said, "Why, what evil hath He done?"

But the Jews told Pilate that Jesus had made Himself equal with God, and so He must die.

Then Pilate was more afraid than ever, and went again into the hall, and asked Jesus where He had come from?

But Jesus gave him no answer.

At length the Jews clamoured so loudly, and told Pilate that he was not Cæsar's friend, that though Pilate longed to release Jesus, when he heard them say that, he gave in to them, and brought Jesus forth for the last time, saying to them, "Behold your King!"

And they all cried out, "Away with Him, crucify Him!"

"The head that once was crowned with thorns
Is crowned with glory now:
A royal diadem adorns
The mighty Victor's brow.

"The highest place that heaven affords
Is His, is His by right:
The King of kings, and Lord of lords,
And heaven's eternal light."

XXI. Jesus Carrying His Cross

And after they had mocked Jesus, they took off the gorgeous robe in which Herod and his soldiers had dressed Him, and they put His own clothes on Him again, and led Him away to crucify Him.

And Jesus—the King of glory—went forth, carrying the cross on which He was to be crucified for us!

Thus our dear Lord left the city where He had been rejected and condemned, bearing His heavy, cruel cross.

I think He must have fainted beneath its weight, for we are told that when they came to the gate of the city, they met a man, Simon the Cyrenian, coming in from the country, and the soldiers forced him to carry the cross after Jesus.

A great multitude came out after them, and the women who had followed and loved Jesus were mourning and grieving at their dear Lord's

sorrowful fate.

But Jesus turned to them and told them not to cry for Him, but for all the sorrow which was coming upon Jerusalem because the Jews would not have Him for their Saviour.



HE MUST HAVE FAINTED BENEATH ITS WEIGHT.

And there were two other men led out with Jesus to be crucified at the same time. They were called malefactors, because they had been very

wicked.

So the whole great company went outside the city walls, and they bring Jesus to a place called "The Skull." They offered our dear Lord some wine and myrrh to drink, but, when He had tasted it, He would not take it.

Then they crucified Jesus, our King, and the two malefactors, one on the right hand and the other on the left, and Jesus in the midst.

Children, in all His dreadful sufferings and sorrow, what is it we hear from those dear lips?

Then Jesus said,—

"Father, forgive them; for they know not what they do."

XXII. The Cross of Jesus

We pause at this picture, dear children, with awe and reverence, and as we gaze upon it our hearts are filled with love and grief.

"Did Jesus bear that cruel death for me?" we whisper to ourselves.
"Was my name on His heart when He hung all those hours on the cross?
Were my sins pardoned by His most precious blood, which flowed from His bleeding side?"

If we can answer a solemn "yes" to these questions, then the cross of Jesus our Saviour is the place where henceforth we can find joy, and thankfulness, and strength.

On the cross where Jesus was crucified, a piece of parchment was nailed. This was generally done, so that people should know what the crime was for which any one was to suffer this cruel death.

But Pilate had nothing to charge Jesus with. He had said over and over again, "I find no fault in Him." And when he sat down to write His accusation on the parchment, he wrote—

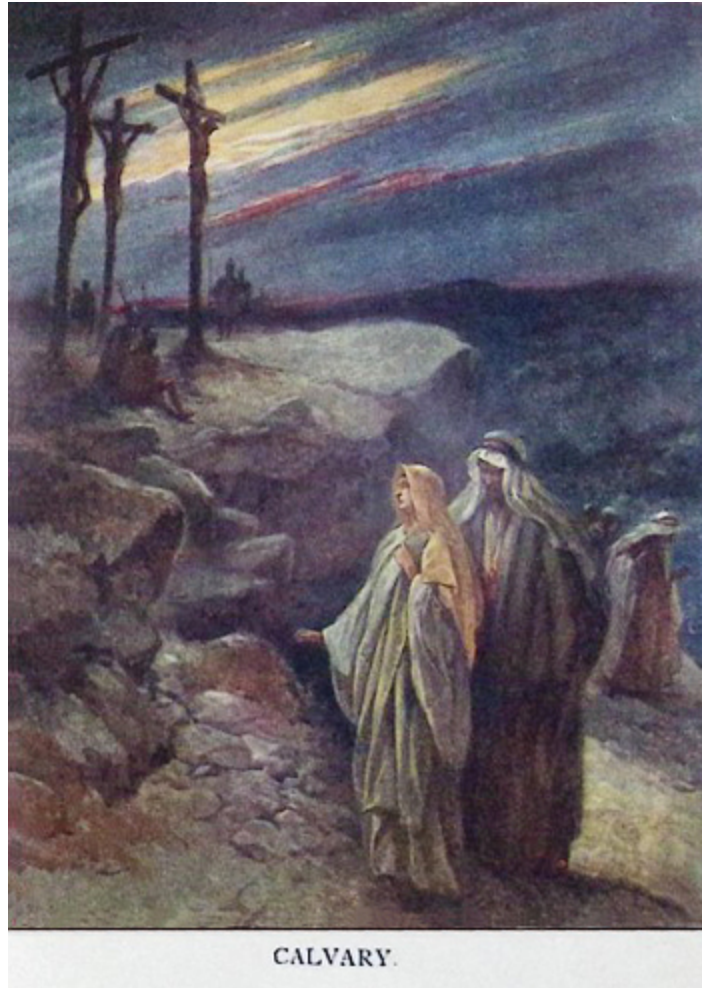
"Jesus of Nazareth—the King of the Jews."

This writing was read by many of the Jews, because the place where Jesus was crucified was near to the city, and many were passing backwards and forwards at this Passover feast time.

And Pilate wrote it in Hebrew and Greek and Latin.

The Jews did not at all like what Pilate had written, and wanted him to take the writing down. They said, "Do not say that He is the King of the Jews! But say, He said He was."

But Pilate would not alter it. "What I have written, I have written," he said.



CALVARY.

CALVARY.

So when Jesus died, He had only this accusation—that He is King!

And the people stood beholding.

They saw the four soldiers carry away His raiment, to divide it between them. But when the soldiers found that His coat, or under-robe, was seamless and woven in one piece, they cast lots for that; so that the Scripture, written hundreds of years before, might be fulfilled, "They parted My raiment among them, and for my vesture they did cast lots." These things, therefore, the soldiers did.

Then the rulers who were standing by mocked Him, saying, "He saved others, why did He not save Himself and come down from the cross?"

Dear children, do you know why Jesus did not come down from the cross?

"He knew how wicked man had been,
He knew that God must punish sin;
So, out of pity, Jesus said
He'd bear the punishment instead.

"And so He died! And this is why
He came to earth to bleed and die:
The Bible says He came from heaven,
That we might have our sins forgiven."

Perhaps some of you may think that the cruel nails held His dear hands and feet so fast that He could not come down?

But that was not the reason—oh no!

It was love that made Him stay there—love to you and to me. He stayed there that He might die for us, that His precious blood should be shed to pay the price for our sins.

The two thieves who were crucified on either side of Jesus, joined with the Jews in reproaching Him; but after a while one of them began to think of Him as He hung there in all His patience and love, and he was sorry that he had spoken against Him. He rebuked the other thief, and told him that they both were condemned justly, "but this Man hath done nothing amiss," he said.

And then we can picture him, turning his poor suffering face towards the loving Saviour who hung beside him, and we can almost hear him

saying, "Lord, remember me when Thou comest into Thy Kingdom!"

And Jesus answered and said, "To-day shalt thou be with Me in Paradise!"

Ah! He was the King of Love! Not a reproach to that sinful man; not a word that now it was too late; nothing but love and cheer and tenderness. "Verily I say unto thee, To-day, thou shalt be with Me in Paradise!"

Oh, does not this tender Jesus make your heart grow warm with love?

Though He was racked with pain, He could cheer one who was suffering by Him; though He was dying for the sins of the whole world, He could save one single soul who turned to Him in faith.

God sent a great darkness over all the land from twelve o'clock till three o'clock, while His holy Son was dying on the cross.

No one can tell all the depth of woe and loneliness which Jesus suffered while the load of our sins rested upon Him; but the more we understand it, the more we shall love Him for His great love.

"When I survey the wondrous cross
On which the Prince of Glory died,
My richest gain I count but loss,
And pour contempt on all my pride.

"Forbid it, Lord, that I should boast
Save in the death of Christ my God:
All the vain things that charm me most,
I sacrifice them to His blood.

"See from His head, His hands, His feet,
Sorrow and love flow mingled down:
Did e'er such love and sorrow meet?
Or thorns compose so rich a crown?

"Were the whole realm of nature mine,
That were an offering far too small:
Love so amazing, so divine,
Demands my soul, my life, my all.

"To Christ, who won for sinners grace
By bitter grief and anguish sore,
Be praise from all the ransomed race
For ever and for evermore."

Now there were standing by the cross of Jesus, His mother, and His mother's sister Mary, the wife of Cleophas, and Mary Magdalene.

When Jesus saw His mother, and John, the disciples whom He loved, standing there, He charged him to take care of His dear mother; and John took her to his own home from that hour.

And now everything was done which the Scriptures had said should happen; and Jesus, knowing this, said, "I thirst!"

And one ran and filled a sponge with vinegar and put it on hyssop, and put it to His mouth.

And when Jesus had received the vinegar, He said, "It is finished!" And He gave up His spirit into His Father's keeping; and then He died.

XXIII. The Sealed Tomb

Now when the centurion who was in charge of the soldiers who crucified Jesus, saw all the things that had happened—His wonderful love and patience, His dying words, the darkness and the great earthquake,—he feared greatly, and said, "Truly this was the Son of God!"

And there were many women there, standing as near as they dared. Among these was Mary Magdalene, out of whom Jesus had cast seven devils; and Mary the mother of James and Joses; and Salome the mother of Zebedee's children, James and John, the disciples who had been with Jesus in the Garden of Gethsemane, and at other special times during His ministry.

So these women stood and waited near the cross all those long hours till the evening, to see what they would do with their Lord.

And when the evening had come, there came a rich man of Arimathea, named Joseph.

He was a counsellor and much respected among the Jews; and when the Lord had been condemned by them, he had not consented to what they had done. He was looking for the Kingdom of God, like many other godly Jews at that time.

So he brought fine linen to wrap the precious body of Jesus in; and sweet spices for His burial.

And he went boldly in to Pilate and begged him to give him the body of Jesus.

So Pilate gave him leave, and Joseph hastened back to take Jesus down from the cross, and to wrap Him in beautiful pure linen, and to carry Him away to his own new tomb which was in a garden close to Calvary.

We are told by those who have been there, that just beneath that hill outside Jerusalem called The Skull, there is a garden with a tomb in it, cut out of the rock. It is thought by some, that this is the tomb in which Jesus was laid; but no one can be quite certain that this is so.

At any rate, we are told in the Gospel of John that the garden was near at hand. And here they buried the body of our dear Lord, and rolled a great stone across the door of the sepulchre.

And Mary Magdalene and the other Mary saw where He was laid, and sat down over against the sepulchre to watch.

But the next day, the chief priests and Pharisees came to Pilate, to remind him that Jesus had said while He was alive, that He was going to rise again from the dead on the third day.

So they begged Pilate to command that the sepulchre should be made sure till the third day, lest Jesus' disciples should come in the night and steal His body away, and pretend that He had risen as He had said, which they thought would be a worse mistake than all!

And Pilate answered, "You have soldiers who can watch, go and make it as sure as you can."

So they went back, and made the sepulchre sure, sealing the stone, and setting men to keep watch all night.

XXIV. The Resurrection

They had sealed the grave to make all sure, and they had set a watch that no one should come to steal the body of Jesus; and the women and those who loved Him and had followed Him, left the tomb at last, and went to their own homes.



SETTING MEN TO WATCH ALL NIGHT.

SETTING MEN TO WATCH ALL NIGHT.

They had forgotten that the Lord Jesus had told them, over and over again, that He would rise from the dead on the third day.

But it was impossible that the grave could hold the Son of God, when the time came for Him to rise.

He tasted death for all of us; but He also rose from the dead to show that God was satisfied that He had atoned for our sins.

Very early on the first day of the week, which is our Sunday, Mary Magdalene, and Salome, and "the other Mary," came to the grave with spices and sweet-smelling ointments to anoint the body of Jesus.

And as they went along, they said to each other, "Who shall roll away the stone for us?" For they knew that it was very large and heavy!

But when they got there, the stone was already rolled away.

So they entered into the tomb, and they saw a young man sitting there on the right side, clothed in a long, white garment, and they were very frightened.

But he said to them, "Do not be frightened; you are looking for Jesus of Nazareth, who was crucified: He is risen; He is not here: look at the place where they laid Him. And go and tell His disciples, and Peter, that if they go into Galilee they shall see Him, as He said to them."

At first they were so frightened at the shining angel that they ran away, and did not tell any one. But very soon, while it was yet very early, Jesus met Mary Magdalene (out of whom, we read in the 8th of Luke, He had cast seven devils), and when she had seen Him and He had talked with her, she knew certainly that He was the Lord; and she ran and told His other disciples who were mourning and crying because they thought He was dead, and that they should never see Him again.

And do you not think, too, that Peter must have been very glad indeed of that special message which the Lord Jesus sent to him?

We read afterwards that the Lord also appeared to Peter; but we do not know what He said to His sorrowful disciple. All we do know is that Jesus forgave him.

And this is what He will do for us, children, if we ask Him to forgive us. He will comfort us with the assurance of His love and pardon, and He will help us to go on again like He did Peter.

Meanwhile the soldiers who were watching at the tomb were very frightened at all that had happened, and went and told the chief priests all about it.

So when they had consulted together, they gave the soldiers money, and told them to say that the disciples of Jesus had come in the night and had stolen His body.

So that saying was believed among the Jews from that time.

But Jesus was alive! He showed Himself over and over again to His own disciples; and so that there should be no mistake, He came one evening into the midst of the room where the disciples and those who were with them were assembled, and said, "Peace be unto you!"

They were all so frightened, thinking that they had seen a spirit, that Jesus told them to touch Him and to look at the marks of the nails in His hands and feet; and when they could hardly believe for joy, He asked them to give Him some food, and He sat down and ate it before them, explaining to them in loving words that it was necessary for Him to die, but also necessary for Him to rise again, that He might obtain eternal salvation for all who will obey Him.

XXV. On the Shore at Dawn

On the day of the resurrection, two of the disciples of the Lord Jesus were walking from Jerusalem to the village of Emmaus, and as they went along they spoke of all that had happened, reasoning together about it.

And as they walked, Jesus Himself drew near, and went with them. But their eyes were holden that they did not know Him.

So He asked them what they were talking of, and why they were sad?

And Cleopas answered, that He must be a stranger in Jerusalem if He did not know what had so lately happened there.

And Jesus asked them, "What things?"

So they told Him it was about Jesus of Nazareth who had been a mighty prophet, but now had been crucified; and how they had hoped that He was to be their Saviour.

Then Jesus told them that if they had only believed, they would have understood that the Scriptures had foretold that Christ must suffer to atone for sin, and then to enter into His glory.

So He explained in all the Scriptures the things about Himself—but still they did not know Him.

Then they came to the village, and they pressed Him to abide with them; and while they sat at supper Jesus blessed the bread, and brake it, and gave to them.

Then their eyes were opened, and they knew Him, and He vanished out of their sight.

So they rose up the same hour and hurried back to Jerusalem, where they found the eleven disciples together, who were full of the joyful news that the Lord had risen indeed, and that He had appeared to Peter.

Then Cleopas and his companion told their great news, and as they did so, Jesus Himself stood in their midst, and said to them, "Peace be unto you!"

* * * * *

Now I must tell you how Jesus showed Himself to six of His disciples and Nathanael at the sea of Galilee, sometimes called Tiberias.

Peter had proposed one evening to go to fish on the lake, and the others had said they would go with him. But all that night they took nothing. When the morning dawned they were cold and hungry, and as the light came back they saw some one on the shore who seemed to be waiting for them.

They did not know that it was Jesus and even when His voice came to them across the water, asking if they had anything to eat, they did not recognize it.

But when the stranger called to them to cast their nets on the right side of the ship, and they found a lot of fish, John began to guess Who it must be, and he said to Peter, "It is the Lord!"

Then Peter threw on his fisher's coat and cast himself into the sea to get quickly to his beloved Lord, and the rest hastened to follow in a small boat, dragging the net full of great fishes.

When they landed on the beach, they found that Jesus had prepared for them. He knew that they were cold and hungry, and they saw a fire already lighted, with some fish being cooked on it, as well as bread to eat with it.

Then Jesus told them to bring some of the fish which they had caught; and He said to them, "Come and break your fast." But none of the disciples durst ask Him, "Who art Thou?" knowing that it was the Lord.

Jesus then came to them, and gave them fish and bread, and satisfied their hunger. But oh, what must it have been to have His presence, and to see Him once more, face to face!

You can picture them as they sat in that clear morning air with Jesus close to them and how they must have listened to every word that fell from His dear lips. And what do you think was the message that He wanted them to remember, above all, from that resurrection breakfast table?

When they had finished their meal, Jesus turned to Simon Peter—Peter who loved Him so truly, and yet who had denied Him,—and He said tenderly to him three times, "Simon, son of Jonas, do you love Me?"

And Peter answered each time, "Yes, Lord, Thou knowest that I love Thee!"

And Jesus said to him words like this: "Then, Peter, if you love Me, feed My lambs, and feed My sheep!"

Jesus did not mean, children, that Peter should turn into a shepherd. No; He wanted Peter to understand that among the people of God, whom God often calls His flock, there would be little lambs—children—who would want cherishing, and sheep who would want feeding, with the Bread of Life.

I think this was the message of that resurrection breakfast table: "If you love Me, tell others of My great love!"

XXVI. Going to the Father

At length the time came for the Lord Jesus to return to heaven, to be at His Father's right hand.

So one day He led His disciples out of Jerusalem to the Mount of Olives.

He did not tell them to wait for Him at Gethsemane that day! All sorrow and suffering were now past for Him. He had finished the work which His Father had given Him to do, and now He had only to bless His disciples, and ascend up above the clouds to live with His Father.

During the forty days since His resurrection, He had appeared to them many times, and had told them many things about the kingdom of God, and about the Holy Spirit who was soon to be sent to them to be their Comforter.

And now having led them out as far as Bethany, He blessed them, and while He blessed them, He was parted from them, and carried up into heaven, and a cloud received Him out of their sight.

While they looked earnestly up to heaven, two angels stood by them in white clothes, and said to them, "Why stand ye gazing up into heaven? This same Jesus, which is taken up from you into heaven, shall so come in like manner, as ye have seen Him go into heaven."

Then they returned back to Jerusalem with great joy.

It was the thought of Jesus being in glory which gave them great joy; and His promise that He would come again some day, made them happy and hopeful.

They had lost His dear bodily presence here; but He said that though He was in heaven, He would be with them here too, even to the end of the world.

This is what He says to us, dear children, to-day! He says, "I am with you all the days, and I am coming again to receive you to Myself, that where I am, there you may be also."

Jesus wants us all to set to work for Him. He has left us a charge to tell others about His love in dying for us, that they may come to Him to be blessed.

We may not be able to do very much, but we can try to please Him every day by being obedient, faithful and loving; and while we listen to His voice saying to us from the glory, "Surely I come quickly!" We can answer Him with adoring love,—

"Come, Lord Jesus!"

XXVII. When the Earth was made Beautiful

Long ago, before this earth was made ready for us to live on, if you had been able to look at it, you would have seen nothing but mist, and darkness, and water!

And as you think about it, you wonder very much how it all was.

If you were asked, you would say that the earth is a great round ball, and that it hangs up in the sky without anybody holding it up!

You cannot explain how that is, and you find it very difficult to understand how it can be.

Perhaps you wonder who made the earth? And how did it get hung up in the sky, and who keeps it there?

So I am going to tell you about it.

A very, very long time ago, a great deal longer ago than you or I can count, for the Bible tells us that it was "In the beginning," God made the heaven and the earth.

The earth on which we live now, where there are trees and beautiful flowers, and horses and cows, as well as men and women and children, was quite empty then. It was always dark there in those days, and all the ground was covered with water!

You can think how desolate it must have been: nothing to be seen but mist and darkness!

But God had not forgotten this earth of ours.

And we read another thing in the Bible about "In the beginning," and that is, that Jesus the Son of God was "in the beginning with God."

That is such a comforting thought! Before our world was prepared for us to live on, Jesus was with God in Heaven!

You children love your fathers and mothers very much; you like to go on their messages, and to do what you can to help them, do you not? The Lord Jesus loved to do God's will, and to carry out all His Father gave Him to do.

And what do you think God did give Him to do? Perhaps you have begun to guess!

God His Father gave Him the wonderful work of making our earth, and preparing it all for us to live on!

It says in the Bible "All things were made by Him, and without Him was not anything made that was made."

So the first thing that happened when God began to prepare this earth for men to live on, was that God's Spirit came and "brooded" over the dark waters that covered the earth.

You wonder what that means? Perhaps you have seen a hen sitting day after day on the nest of eggs, and "brooding" over them till they get warmth and life?

Well, that is what the word means! God's Holy Spirit came near our earth, and surrounded it with His warmth and love.

And then God said, "Let there be light!" or "Let the light come!"

And lo! Instead of the dark waters and deep shadow, there came a shining over the earth; and God called the light Day, and the darkness He called Night.

Next to the day and night, God made the air and the sky and the clouds. And He told the sea to stay where it was, and the sky to stay above the earth, and He called the sky Heaven.

But still there was no land to be seen; so in His wonderful power, God told the sea to go back to a certain distance, and then the mountains and the hills and the plains stood out, and the earth was ready to be furnished for us men, who were to live on it.

So God our Father, and Jesus Christ our Saviour, and the Holy Spirit our Comforter, all prepared this beautiful earth for us.

It is God's power (by His wonderful laws) which holds the earth up in the sky, so that it does not tumble out of its place.

And it is His power which brought the trees and the grass, the flowers and the corn, the fruit and the vegetables to make us happy.

And now came something else.

God planned for us to have the beautiful sun to cheer us, and to tell us what time of day it is; and He gave us the moon to shine at night, and also to remind us what time of the month we have reached. He set them in the sky to make us happy, and to remind us every day of His love and power. Then God made the fishes and the birds, the cattle and the sheep, as well as the lions and tigers, the horses and the elephants.

And not only the large animals, but the little ants and bees and caterpillars—everything that lives on this earth.

But there were no men or women or children there, yet.

Then God talked to the Lord Jesus about it; for we are told in the first Chapter of Genesis that He said "Let us make man . . . after our likeness."

So God made Adam and Eve, and blessed them, and promised to give them some little children, and told them He had made everything on the earth to make them happy and to do them good.

And then God saw that His work was very good; nothing had been left out, it was perfect! Every leaf was perfect, every flower, every insect, every animal, every star; all were very good!

Thus the heavens and the earth were made, and God rested on the seventh day, and blessed the seventh day, because in it, He rested from all His work which He had done.

This is why we have Sunday; and we shall find that in keeping His day of Holy Rest, we too are promised a great blessing for "in keeping His Commandments there is great reward."

XXVIII. Adam and Eve

When God made the earth ready for men and women and children to live in, He made a beautiful garden called Eden, and there God put Adam and Eve who were the first man and the first woman.



THE GARDEN OF EDEN

In this garden they were very good and happy. God himself used to come down and talk to them in the cool of the evening.

He told Adam and Eve that He had made everything for them, and that the trees with their sweet fruit were for their food.

But God gave them one command. He said they were not to eat the fruit of one particular tree in the garden. God knew the fruit of this tree would make Adam and Eve very unhappy, if they ate it.

Now I must explain to you that there were some of God's angels who had been very disobedient, and they had been shut out of heaven because

they would not obey God.

Adam and Eve were very happy, as I said, and they did not think of disobeying God till Satan (that wicked angel who tries to make us do naughty things) hid himself in a serpent, and came to Eve and began to talk to her.

Eve was not surprised that a serpent could talk to her, for so many wonderful things were around her, that she listened to him, and answered him, without thinking it was any harm.

This is how temptation often comes to us, children!

Satan began by asking Eve a very clever question. He said, "Are you sure God has said that you may not eat of every tree in the garden?"

Then Eve said eagerly, "We may eat of every tree except one; but if we eat of that one we shall have to die!"

Then the serpent said to Eve, "You will not have to die! You will only be a great deal more wise than you are now!"

And so Eve looked longingly at the tree, and when she saw that the fruit looked so nice, and heard that it would make her clever, she forgot all about obeying God, and picked the fruit and ate it, and gave some to Adam her husband, and he ate it too.



PICKED THE FRUIT AND ATE IT.

PICKED THE FRUIT AND ATE IT.

Oh, how sad was their disobedience, and what sorrow it brought on them and their children!

So the Lord God sent them out of the beautiful garden, because there was in the midst of the garden the Tree of Life, and God did not wish them to eat of that tree now.

So He put angels at the gate of Eden with a flaming sword, to keep the way of the Tree of Life.

Then Adam and Eve went out sorrowfully from their lovely garden, and Adam had to work very hard in digging the ground to plant things to grow for that food.

Eve was very sad too, and in the end they both had to die, as God had said.

But God is very pitiful, and when He was telling Eve how wrong she had been, and what a cruel enemy the Serpent was, He promised her that some day a Deliverer should come, who should destroy the serpent, Satan.

This Deliverer is Jesus Christ our Saviour, Who came to earth to live and to die for us, that He might undo all that Satan had done to hurt us, and make all who will trust Jesus, happy in heaven for ever.

And in the Revelation, we read a beautiful promise, which tells us something about Heaven that we never could have guessed when we saw poor Adam and Eve driven out of Eden—

"To him that overcometh will I give to eat of the Tree of Life, which is in the midst of the Paradise of God!"

XXIX. Cain and Abel

By and by God gave Adam and Eve two sons. The eldest was named Cain, who helped Adam till the ground; and the younger was named Abel, who was a keeper of sheep.

After a time, both these young men brought an offering to the Lord; and the Lord accepted the offering of Abel, which was a lamb from the flock, but He could not accept the offering of fruit which Cain brought.

Perhaps you wonder at that, dear children? But I will try to explain it to you. God looks on the heart, and Abel's heart was obedient. He brought that which God had appointed as the way to come to Him. But Cain was not obedient; he thought that the fruit of the ground which he had taken such trouble to grow, would do just as well!

So when he found that God did not accept his offering, he was very angry, and his countenance fell.

And the Lord said to him, "Why are you angry, Cain? If you do well, shall it not be accepted? And if you do not do well, a Sin-offering lies at the door."

I think that GOD meant Cain to understand that it was only by a Sacrifice that we can come near to Him. And when, all through the Old Testament, we read of the sacrifice of a lamb as an offering for sin, God accepted the lamb, because He looked on to the time when the Lord Jesus would be "The Lamb of God, which taketh away the sin of the world."

But Cain did not heed God's gentle persuasion, that he too could bring a sin-offering; and presently, when he was alone with his brother, he got more and more angry, and at last rushed at him and struck him and killed him!

Oh, the misery of poor Cain! No one can tell how he longed to undo that cruel deed. No one knows the sorrow and punishment of his whole life.

Children, let it be a warning to us not to let anger and jealousy live in our hearts, but let us pray every day, "Deliver me from Satan, the Evil one, who would tempt me to sin against Thee, and accept me, for Jesus' sake!"

XXX. The Escape from Sodom

Then the two angels rose up and went towards Sodom, and the Lord remained talking with Abraham.

He told Abraham that He intended to destroy Sodom, because the city was so very wicked!

Now Abraham knew that his nephew Lot was living there, and he begged God to spare Sodom if there were fifty good people there. And the Lord promised to spare it if there were!

But Abraham began to fear there were not so many; and he kept on asking the Lord, till at last he got down to ten! and the Lord said He would spare it for ten's sake.

And then the Lord went on His way, and Abraham went back to his home.

But when the angels got to Sodom, they could not even find ten who loved God!

They found Lot and his family, and urged them to escape for their lives across the plain, and not once to look behind them, for Sodom was going to be burned all up!

So Lot escaped with his wife and two daughters and fled for his life. But his wife was disobedient to God's message, and turned to look back, and she was turned into a pillar of salt.

And so the great and wicked city was destroyed by a terrible judgment from the Lord, but Lot was saved!

Dear children! God has sent Jesus to be our Saviour, let us fly to Him from our sins, and so be safe for ever in His happy, happy land.

XXXI. The Tower of Babel

"What a great tower!" says someone. "And how high it is! Look; the houses are so small down there on that great sort of field, and the tower is going to be built higher still, because, you see, it is not finished!"

You are quite right! That beautiful tower never was finished, though it was begun four thousand years ago!

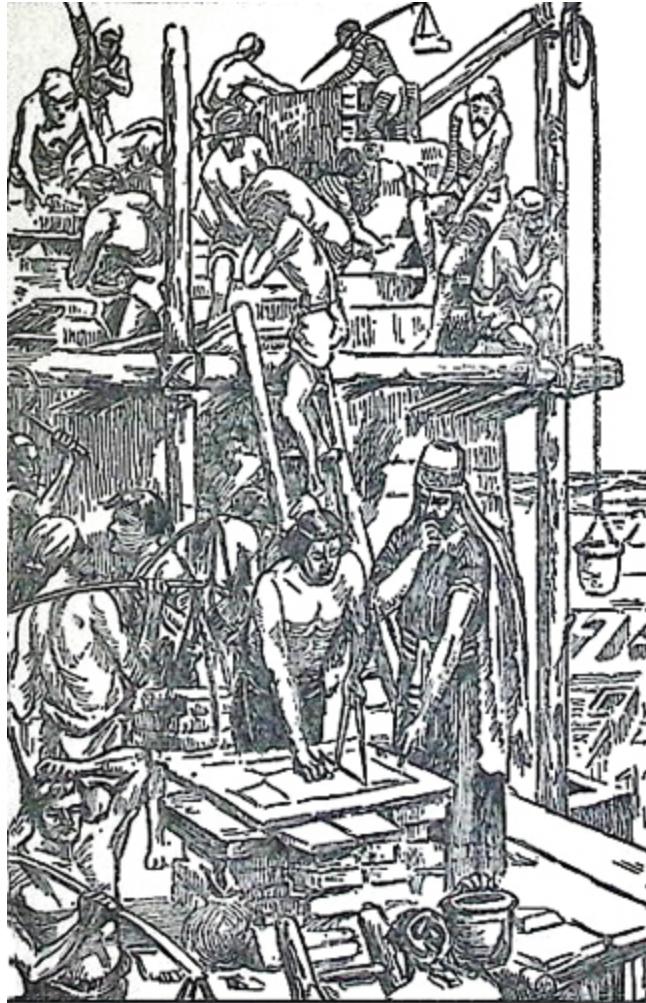
I told you about the Flood; and this is the next story after the Flood.

You remember that when the rain stopped, and God allowed the waters to go down, the tops of the mountains began to be seen, and then the green fields were uncovered, and Noah and his children and all the animals were able to come out of the Ark, and to begin to live on the earth again.

But, alas, as men began to increase on the earth, they began to forget God, and the way He had saved them in the Ark. But they remembered the flood, and they thought in their pride, that they would build a very high tower whose top should reach to Heaven, so that no flood could overwhelm them any more.

But there was another thing they forgot; and that was God's promise to them, that He never would send a flood to destroy the world again.

Then God came down from Heaven to see all that the men on the earth were doing. And when He saw their pride and their forgetfulness of Him, the Lord said, Let us go down and prevent the men from understanding each other's speech.



THEY WOULD BUILD A VERY HIGH TOWER.

THEY WOULD BUILD A VERY HIGH TOWER.

And when God had done this, the men could not speak to each other about their work as they used. It was just as if someone were to speak German or Italian or Spanish to you and expect you to understand.

So the men could not build any more, for no one could understand what the others said. So they left off building and were scattered to all parts of the earth; and the city they had tried to build was called Babel—which means Confusion.

But God did not forget His servant Noah, nor Noah's good son Shem. He took care of Shem and of his children after him, and by and by of Shem's grandchildren and great-grandchildren, till at length Abraham was born.

And Abraham had the great honour of being called The Friend of God!

Perhaps you think how much you would like to be called such a name as that?

Then let all of us who would like to be called God's friends set out to be obedient.

God has put in the Bible rules which are to guide us every day. If we follow them, that is being obedient.

Do you remember what the Lord Jesus said about that, when He was on earth?

Here are the words,—

"Ye are My friends, if ye do whatsoever I command you."

"For whosoever shall do the Will of My Father which is in Heaven, the same is My brother and sister and mother."

XXXII. The Friend of God

"Now the Lord had said to Abram, Get thee out of thy country, and from thy father's house, unto a land which I will shew thee; and I will make

of thee a great nation, and I will bless thee . . . and in thee shall all families of the earth be blessed."

So Abram obeyed, and went out from Ur of the Chaldees, and came into the land of Canaan.

God had given Abram most wonderful promises, as well as frequent assurances of His love. He was also very rich, for God had given him a great deal of money, and many sheep and oxen and camels.

But there was one thing which God had not given Abram, which he longed for very much; and this was a little child of his very own.

God loved Abram, and He would not have denied him his desire without some wise and loving reason.

God promised Abram that he should have a son, but He wished to prove to all the world, and to the angels who are looking on at what happens on this earth, that Abram could trust Him, and trust His promise even though he should have to wait twenty years for it.

Abram had brought his wife Sarah, and his nephew Lot with him, when he left his own country; but after a time he and Lot had so many sheep and oxen that there was not grass enough for them all; so Lot chose the land towards Sodom, and Abram dwelt in the land of Canaan.

One day the word of God came to Abram in a vision or dream, saying, "Fear not, Abram, I am thy shield, and thy exceeding great reward!"

Then Abram told the Lord how he wanted a son of his own, for he had no one to take all his riches by and by, except the servant who managed his property.

And God promised Abram that he should have a son of his very own.

And God led him out in the night when all the beautiful stars were shining in the deep blue sky, and God said, "Look now towards heaven, and

tell the stars if thou be able to count them"; and God said, "So shall the number of your children be!"

And Abram believed in the Lord, and He counted it to him for righteousness.

Do you not think, children, that as Abram walked on those lonely mountains in Palestine, that he must often have thought "God has promised all this land to me and my children!" And then, when he looked up at the stars at night in the clear atmosphere, that he must have been lost in wonder at the thousands and thousands of stars which he saw, and have said to himself, "God promised so shall my seed be!"

The Lord Jesus, in the New Testament, tells us something about Abraham which we do not read in Genesis.

He said "Abraham rejoiced to see my day, he saw it and was glad!"

How wonderful it is that God notices and remembers when we try to please Him, and sees our hearts when nobody else can!

At length Abram was ninety years old, and the Lord appeared to him again, and told him that his name should not be called Abram any more, but Abraham, because he was to be a father of many nations. And then God told Abraham that very soon he and Sarah were to have a little son, and that his name was to be called Isaac.

So one day Abraham was sitting at the door of his tent in the heat of the day, when he looked up and saw three men standing by him; and when he saw them, he ran to meet them and bowed himself to the ground.

Perhaps Abraham guessed that one of the three men was the Lord; for afterwards he did not seem at all surprised when the Lord spoke to him, and promised to give Sarah a little son very soon.

At any rate he begged the three men to rest beneath the tree while he hastened away to prepare food to refresh them.

Then he took butter and milk and a young calf which he had cooked, and set it before them and he stood by under the tree, and they did eat.

Then they asked him where Sarah was, and Abraham answered that she was in the tent.

And the Lord said, "I will certainly return and Sarah, thy wife, shall have a son."

Now Sarah was just inside the tent, and when she heard the words, she laughed within herself.

And the Lord said to Abraham, "Why did Sarah laugh, saying, 'Shall I of a surety have a child?' Is anything too hard for the Lord? At the time appointed I will return unto thee, and Sarah shall have a son."

And Sarah was ashamed that she had doubted God's promise, and she denied, saying, "I did not laugh," for she was afraid.

But the Lord said, "Nay, but thou didst laugh."

XXXIII. In a Thirsty Land

This is a nice story for children, because it tells us that God listens when children pray, and sympathizes with all that happens to children.

The boy you see in the picture is almost dying for want of water. Perhaps none of you children know how dreadful it is to be really very thirsty, and have nothing to drink, however thirsty you may be.

Hagar, the mother of the boy, is very sad. She knows that the bottle is empty, and she cannot see any sign of a well, or of a spring of water, in the

great sandy desert which stretches in every direction as far as the eye can see.

Ishmael is her one child, and God has allowed them to be sent out into the wilderness, with only a bottle of water and as much bread as they can carry; for Hagar had been turned out of her home, and had been obliged to take that long and dangerous journey, because of the unkindness of her mistress Sarah.

But God was watching over her and Ishmael. He would not allow anything to really hurt them, and in His great pity, He sent to save them when all other help had failed.

By and by there was not one drop of water left in the bottle, and Ishmael had no strength to walk any further.

Hagar knew that all hope was over, now that Ishmael could not walk another step! So she laid him down under a little shrub that grew there, and went some little distance off, for she said in her grief, "I cannot bear to see him die."

So she sat down in her misery and cried bitterly.

But God heard the voice of the lad, and He sent His angel to call to Hagar from heaven. "What is the matter, Hagar? Do not be afraid, for God has heard the voice of the lad, where he is. Arise, lift up the lad and hold him in thine hand; for I will make of him a great nation."

Then God opened her eyes and she saw a well of water; and she went and filled the bottle with water, and gave the lad drink, and he revived, and presently got quite well.

And this is the lesson which we may learn from Ishmael's cry, children.

God knows our difficulties; God hears us when we speak to Him; God is nearer than we think; God is more loving than the most loving of earthly friends. He tells us to call upon Him in trouble.

Let us think of Ishmael dying for want of water, and crying to God in his distress, and let us do the same in our troubles!

No matter how small they may seem, God says He cares.

Let us take courage, then; and if God whispers to us when we are sorrowful (like He did to Hagar), "What aileth thee—what is the matter?" Let us listen for another whisper, for He will surely finish the sentence to us, as He did to Hagar, with the cheering words, "Fear not!"

XXXIV. The Offering of Isaac

So Abraham was given his dear little son Isaac, and he was the delight of Abraham's life, and of Sarah's too.

But by and by, God wished to try Abraham's faith more than even in that long waiting time for Isaac. God was going to ask him to do about the hardest thing that a man could be asked to do.

God told Abraham that he was to take his dear son whom he so fondly loved, and to go to a mountain a long way off, in the land of Moriah, and to offer him up to God as a sacrifice.

This was to try Abraham's obedience and faith.

Was he to take Isaac! On whom all his hopes rested, who was the joy of his life, and through whom all the world was to be blessed; was he to lay him upon the altar, and offer him up to God, as he did the lambs from his flock?

But Abraham did not hesitate. If God told him to do a thing, he obeyed. He knew that God could even raise Isaac from the dead, if He

thought good. At any rate he had nothing to do, but to obey!

So he got up very early in the morning and saddled his ass, and took two young men with him, and his son, and the wood for the burnt offering, and set out on his journey to the place God had told him of.

The most precious thing Abraham had was that son who was walking beside him. And besides his love for his boy, God had promised that Isaac should live to have a son, and that by and by the Saviour should come into the world as one of Isaac's great-great-great-great-grandchildren!

Isaac was now grown into a strong young man, but he went with his father; and though he asked him on the way, Where was the lamb for the burnt offering? He was satisfied with his father's answer, "My son, God will provide Himself a lamb for a burnt offering."

When they reached the place which God had told him of, Abraham bound Isaac his son, and laid him upon the altar; and then he stretched out his hand with the knife in it, to offer up his son as God had told him.

But as quickly as the knife was raised, so quickly an angel of God called out of heaven, "Abraham, Abraham!"

Oh, how glad Abraham was to draw back that dreadful knife and answer, "Here am I!"

And God said, "Lay not thy hand upon the lad, neither do thou anything to him; for now I know that thou fearest God, seeing thou hast not withheld thy son, thine only son, from ME."

And when Abraham looked up, he saw a ram caught by his horns in a bush; and he took him and offered him up instead of his son.

So Isaac was given back to his loving father, and God was very pleased with Abraham's obedience, and He told him that in Isaac's children, by and by, all the nations of the world should be blessed.

For in about eighteen hundred years after this, the Lord Jesus Christ was coming to this earth to be "The Lamb of God which taketh away the sin of the world"; and I think that when Abraham said, "God Himself will provide a lamb," he was thinking, not only of the saving of Isaac's life, but of that far-off day when Jesus should bear our sins, instead of us, on the Cross of Calvary, that we may go free!

XXXV. A Bargain Between Two Brothers

By and by Isaac grew up to be a man.

Abraham and Sarah heard that in Abraham's old home in Mesopotamia, his brother Nahor had a family of sons and daughters, and they thought it would be very nice if Isaac could have one of these daughters for his wife. So Abraham called Eliezer, his chief servant, and told him to prepare for a long journey, as he wished him to bring back a wife for his son Isaac.

Eliezer was afraid that the maiden would not come so far, but Abraham told him that God would send His angel with him to prosper him on his way.

So Eliezer took some valuable presents, and set out with camels and servants to seek for a wife for his master's son.

He at length reached the city of Nahor, where Abraham used to live. It seems that Eliezer used to pray about everything! If he could not kneel down to pray, he prayed in his heart; and to those who tell God everything, God sends very quick answers.

In those hot countries, the caravans stop outside the city at the well, so that the thirsty men as well as the camels may drink.

Then Eliezer prayed, and asked God to send out the maiden to draw water, who was to be the wife of Isaac, and to point her out to him by her offering to draw water for the camels; and it all happened just as he had prayed.

Rebecca came out of the city with a pitcher upon her shoulder, which she carried to the well and filled with water.

When Eliezer ran to meet her, and asked her for a drink, she hastened to give him some, and offered at once to fill the trough and water all the thirsty camels. Then Eliezer asked her whose daughter she was, and when she told him, he knew at once that God had guided him to the very maiden whom Abraham wanted his son to marry!

Was not this a quick answer? And Eliezer not only asked, but he thanked God for the answer. "And the man bowed down his head and worshipped the Lord."

Then he gave Rebecca some beautiful presents; as well as many precious things for her mother and her brother.

And so Rebecca consented to go back with Eliezer and became Isaac's wife; and Isaac was very glad his father had sent for her all that long way, for he loved her very much.

By and by God sent Isaac and Rebecca two little twin sons, who grew up to be men.

Esau was the elder, and Jacob was the younger.

Esau was a very clever hunter, and lived an adventurous life among the mountains, and was often away for days in his hunting excursions.

Jacob, however, preferred staying quietly at home, living in the tents, and looking after the flocks and herds.

Isaac was now getting old, and he loved Esau the best of his two sons, because Esau often brought him a wild animal from his hunting, and would

cook it for his father and make it into a savoury dish.

But Rebecca loved Jacob the best; and in after years, through her making him such a favourite, she had the greatest sorrow of her life.

One day Esau came in from a long journey, and though he had succeeded in catching and bringing home an animal, he had had nothing to eat for a long time and as he got near to the tents where they all lived, he saw his brother Jacob sitting eating a bowlful of red pottage, which he had just made for himself.

Esau was very faint and hungry, with such hunger as you and I, dear children, have probably never felt. Very likely he had tasted no food that day, and perhaps not the day before. The sight of the steaming bowl of pottage made him feel as if he would give anything he possessed for some of it to stop the pangs of hunger.

Now I am sorry to tell you that Jacob had a very mean character. Though he truly loved God and wished to please Him, his natural character was very shifty.

So when his brother Esau asked him eagerly to give him his bowl of pottage, Jacob did not jump up and press it upon his hungry brother, but he thought it was a good opportunity to make a bargain!

"If I do give it to you, sell me your birthright!" he exclaimed.

Now among the Jews, the birthright of being the eldest son, God had made a great honour. It was most jealously guarded and taken care of; and God gave great blessings with it.

But Esau did not love God truly in his heart, as Jacob did; he was busy with other things, and had never given it a thought that to love and serve God was more important than anything else.

So he said to Jacob, "I am so faint for food that I am ready to die! What good will this birthright do me?"

So Jacob answered, "You must give me your most sacred promise that you sell it to me for this pottage of lentils!"

And Esau promised most solemnly; and so he sold his birthright!

Then Jacob gave Esau some bread, and his pottage of lentils, and Esau ate and drank, and rose up and went away.

And thus, he despised the birthright which God had given him. He was very very sorry afterwards, but he could not undo what he had done.

I think this is a very sorrowful story, because there are so many people like Esau, who turn away from God's best gifts, and seek only the earthly things which will quickly pass away.

Let the lesson to us, dear children, be to love God first and best of all—before food or clothes, or toys, or happiness—to put God first; and when we have Him for our own, He will take care that we shall have all we need to make us happy; and at the end "a Right to the Tree of Life; and we shall enter in through the gates, into the Heavenly City."

XXXVI. The Ladder up to Heaven

Though Jacob loved God truly, he was not very truthful, and had many faults.

This is very sad, but I think knowing about it is a help to you and me, dear children, because we see that in spite of all, God loved him and forgave him, and taught him as He led him through his long life, to try more and more to please Him in everything.

Jacob had bargained with his hungry brother Esau for his Birthright, and had got it from him.

After a time when Isaac, his father, was very old and was soon going to die, Rebecca heard Isaac asking Esau to go out hunting and bring him home some savoury meat, for he wished to bless him before he died.

Directly Esau was gone, Rebecca called Jacob to her, and together they planned to deceive Isaac, who was nearly blind with age, by Jacob's dressing up in Esau's clothes and pretending to be his first-born son.

So Jacob got his father's blessing as well as the Birthright; and Esau was so terribly angry that he said he would kill his brother when his father was dead. When Rebecca heard of this, she begged Jacob to fly to Haran, where her brother Laban lived, and stay there until Esau was pacified.

Then she went to Isaac and told him that they would send Jacob to get a wife from her old home, and Isaac agreed, and Rebecca sent her son away and never saw his face again.

Oh, sad deception! What sorrow it brought on both Rebecca and Jacob!

So Jacob set out on his long journey and one night he came to a lonely places far from any village where people lived.

Jacob was tired and the sun had set, and he had no light to guide him, so he thought he would lie down where he was, and go to sleep till daylight.

Then he had a wonderful dream, and this is what he saw: Right in front of him was a ladder set up on the earth, and it went up till the top reached right to heaven. And he could see the angels of God going up and coming down upon it.

But beyond all, in the radiant glory, the Lord stood above the ladder and spoke to Jacob. He told him that He was the Lord God of Abraham, and of Isaac, and that by and by through his children's children should come the One who was to be the Blessing of the whole world.

We know the name of that Holy One Who is the world's blessing; it is Jesus Christ, Who came into the world to save sinners!

Then Jacob awoke from his dream and said, "Surely the Lord is in this place! . . . This is none other than the gate of heaven!"

So he took the stones on which he had been resting, and set them up for an altar to the Lord, and made a vow that he would serve God all his life, and would give to God the tenth part of everything that God gave to him.

Now it seems to me, children, that this Ladder up to heaven comes into our lives every day.

Jesus, our Saviour, is like the ladder which rested on the earth close to Jacob; and He is gone back to heaven now to be there to help us in every way: that is the top of the ladder which reached to heaven, where the Lord stood and spoke to Jacob.

So when you see this picture, say to yourselves, "Jesus is my ladder! He is close to me here, He is close to God there! He will never leave me nor forsake me; I can send messages and prayers every time I am lonely or in trouble, and He will send back answers if I wait for them."

So Jacob went on his journey over the desert and at length reached the country to the East, where he hoped he would find his mother's relations.

XXXVII. Jacob meets Rachel

One day Jacob sat down by a well, and looking about him he saw a number of flocks coming near and waiting by the mouth of the well, which had a large stone upon it. So he asked the shepherds whether they knew a

man called Laban; and they told him that they did, and that his daughter Rachel was even now coming with her father's flock!

So Jacob was very glad to see Rachel, and went to the well and rolled the stone away, and watered the flock for her. And then he told Rachel that his mother was Rebecca, Laban's sister; and she ran and told her father.



JACOB WAS VERY GLAD TO SEE RACHEL.

JACOB WAS VERY GLAD TO SEE RACHEL.

Then there was great rejoicing, and Laban welcomed Jacob to his home, and he began to take care of the flocks.

When Jacob had been there a month, Laban asked him what wages he would have, and whether he would stay with him? And Jacob gladly consented, for he loved Rachel very much, and promised to serve Laban for seven years, if he would give him Rachel for his wife.

So at the end of the time, Rachel became his wife; and by and by, God sent her a little son called Joseph, who was going to be, many years afterwards, a great ruler in the land of Egypt!

XXXVIII. The Story of Joseph

You have often heard of Joseph's coat of many colours, and of his being sold by his brothers into Egypt.

So I am going to tell you a little about him, and then you will understand how he came to have that beautiful coat. I have read that generally the eldest son was given a bright coloured, beautifully-worked coat; but Joseph was the eleventh son, and Jacob, his father, gave him that pretty coat because he loved him so very much.

When his brothers saw it, they felt very jealous, and hated Joseph because his father made him such a favourite.

Now jealousy is a very wretched feeling. It is wrong as well as wretched. If boys and girls—or grown up people—give way to jealousy, they may by and by do very unkind and wicked things. The Bible says "Jealousy is cruel as the grave," and you will see as we go on with the story of Joseph, how very true it was in his case.

One day Joseph had a very wonderful dream, and he told his brothers about it.

He had dreamed that he and his brothers were binding sheaves of corn in a field, and that his sheaf stood upright, and that all the sheaves of his brothers bowed down to his sheaf.

This displeased his brothers very much, and they hated him more than they did before.

After a time, Jacob sent Joseph to some far-off fields to see how his brothers and the flocks were getting on, for Jacob and his sons were shepherds.

When the brothers saw him coming, they remembered about his dream, and they determined to kill him, and cast his body into a pit.

But Reuben, his eldest brother, wished to save him out of their hands, so he advised them to put him into the pit alive, intending to come presently and take him back to their father.

But while Reuben was away, some merchants came by on camels, on their way down to Egypt, and the brothers decided to sell Joseph to them.

Though the lad wept and besought them not to be so cruel, they would not hear. So the merchants gave them twenty pieces of silver for their brother, and put him on a camel, and took him a long way off to sell him for a slave.

Then the brothers took Joseph's coat of many colours, and dipped it in the blood of a little goat, and carried the coat back to Jacob, telling him they supposed Joseph must have been killed by a wild beast, as that was how they had found his coat!

But "God meant it for good" all the time, and afterwards we see how this was.

So the unkind brothers let their poor father grieve for Joseph for many many years.

Meanwhile Joseph was brought by the merchants down to Egypt, which is the country that joins on to the land of Canaan at the bottom—or south.

The master who bought him from the merchants treated him very kindly, and when he saw how God prospered all that Joseph did, he made him overseer of all his property.

But all at once another trouble came to Joseph! He was falsely accused to his master, and was cast into prison. Still God meant it for good, and Joseph behaved so well in the prison (for God was with him), that the keeper of the prison took the fetters off his feet, and gave him the charge of all the other prisoners.

See, children, what a nice thing it is to serve God in difficult circumstances!

By and by, after a very long time, Joseph was taken to Pharaoh, the great King of Egypt, to tell him the meaning of a wonderful dream, which had frightened him very much.

Thus step by step the slave-boy was being brought to the king's palace.

God gave Joseph wisdom and favour. He was not only able to tell Pharaoh the meaning of his dream, that there would be seven years of plentiful harvests and seven years of famine; but he gave the king such good advice that the Egyptians were delighted, and Pharaoh put Joseph at the head of everything to carry it out.

The advice was, to carefully store up the corn in the good years, so that there would be enough for the bad years.

And it was in those bad years of famine that old Jacob—Joseph's dear father—sent ten of his sons down to Egypt to buy corn.

They had no idea that the great ruler, who, they heard, was selling corn to the hungry people, was their own brother, whom they had sold for a slave thirteen years before!

So they came down to Egypt, and were taken into the presence of Joseph, though they did not recognize who that great prince was. Then they bowed themselves to the ground before him, and asked him if he would sell them some corn for their families!

Joseph knew his brothers at once. They were less changed than he was; but he did not make himself known to them at first.

He asked all about their father, and their youngest brother; and spoke roughly to them, telling them that if they wanted corn, they must go back to fetch their brother Benjamin, that he might see him, if they were true men!

Afterwards he told them that he served God himself, and as he knew their families were hungry, he would give them some corn, but they must go, all the same, and fetch their other brother back.

Oh! How sorry all those ten brothers were for their sin. They remembered now how cruel they had been. They said to each other, "We were verily guilty concerning our brother, in that we saw the anguish of his soul when he besought us, and we would not hear."

But they talked in their own language, and did not know that the great prince understood them; and Joseph hastened away from them and cried. For he was quite ready to forgive them, but he longed to see his brother Benjamin. So he sent nine of them back with the corn to fetch him, and kept one brother in ward till they should come again.

So they returned to Canaan, and poor old Jacob was obliged to spare his youngest boy to go down to Egypt, little thinking that Joseph was alive, and that by and by, in God's best time, he was to see his dear Joseph again, and clasp his son in his arms.

God watches over His people, and promises to make all things work together for good, because they love Him!

XXXIX. Jacob Comes into Egypt

When at last Benjamin reached Egypt, Joseph could hardly help telling his brothers the great secret, that he was alive! But still, he allowed them to set out with their sacks of corn on their homeward journey again; and told his servants to hide his drinking cup in Benjamin's sack. When the party had gone a little way, Joseph's servants were told to overtake them, and to charge them with having stolen his cup!

You can guess how terrified the brothers were at such a charge from the great prince!

They unloaded their asses, and told the Egyptian servants to look for themselves!

But when the cup was really found in Benjamin's sack, they had not a word to say; and as they returned sorrowfully to the house of the great prince, they confessed to each other that God was punishing them for their cruelty to their young brother long ago.

But God saw their sorrow for their sin, and He forgave them, and was going to bring good out of it all.

When they got back to Joseph, after hearing their sorrowful explanation, he could no longer keep in his loving wish to forgive them; and he told them not to grieve, for he was still alive. And then, he sent them all home again, giving his brothers a handsome set of clothes each, and with quantities of presents for his aged father, as well as sending some wagons to the land of Canaan, to fetch his father and all their families down to Egypt, that he might take care of them while the famine lasted.

Joseph sent his father a great many beautiful presents; and when the brothers got back, and told Jacob that Joseph was alive and was ruler over all the land of Egypt, and that he wished his father and all their families to come down to Egypt, the heart of Jacob fainted within him, for he did not believe them.

But when he saw the wagons which Joseph had sent to carry him down to Egypt, "the heart of Jacob their father revived, and Israel said, It is enough; Joseph my son is yet alive: I will go down and see him before I die!"

And children! These wagons of Joseph's have often been a lesson to me!

Like old Jacob, we see God's mercies surrounding us, and yet because we do not believe and trust Him enough, our hearts faint within us at some fresh difficulty that stands in our way, perhaps.

You ask, "What are the wagons, then?"

I think the wagons are a picture to us of the reality of God's promises, and of the reality of the living Jesus.

Jacob said, "Joseph my son is yet alive!"

We may say with tenderest reverence, "Jesus my Saviour is a living Saviour, I will trust myself to Him and follow Him, and one day I shall see Him face to face!"

XL. Moses and the Children of Israel

You often hear in the Bible about "The Children of Israel," and now I am going to tell you how it was they were called by that name.

Long before Jacob and his sons went down to Egypt to live near Joseph, God had met Jacob one night and had given him a new name. God loved Jacob very much, and He did not wish him to be called Jacob any more, because that name meant a Supplanter—one who had taken something away from another—and God forgave Jacob for his deceit, and called him henceforward, Israel.

So, when in after years, he went down to Egypt, he is often called Israel; and thus his twelve sons came to be called "The Children of Israel."

Well, the children of Israel settled down in Egypt, and Joseph was very kind to them, and they lived in the land of Goshen and were very happy.

But after a time another Pharaoh came to the throne, who did not remember Joseph, and all he had done for the Egyptians in that great famine; and this Pharaoh thought that these Jews or children of Israel should be made into slaves, and should build his great cities and pyramids; and he made their lives a terrible burden to them.

But God had not forgotten His great promise to Abraham that his children should live in the land of Canaan; and when the time that God had mentioned to Abraham drew near, He was preparing a great deliverance for them; to take them right out of Egypt back to their own land!

You will now hear how God brought this to pass. His ways are most wonderful!

The King of Egypt, called Pharaoh, was very surprised to find that in spite of all his unkindness, the children of Israel grew to be so many, that he feared they would fill up all the land of Egypt. So he sent out a cruel order that all the little baby boys should be killed as soon as they were born.

Some of the Jews who loved and feared God would not obey the wicked order, and among these was a mother called Jochebed who had a very beautiful baby called Moses.

The very best way when we want to do anything very difficult is to tell God about it, and ask Him to help us. So this Jewish mother did; and then she made a strong basket of bulrushes, over which she put pitch to keep out the water, and then laid her sweet baby in it, and laid the cradle in the bulrushes on the river bank, sending his little sister Miriam to watch him as well as she could.

Think of the greedy crocodiles who might have come up from the river and have eaten little Moses up!



THE FINDING OF MOSES.

THE FINDING OF MOSES.

But God's loving care was over him and he did not get any harm.

By and by the daughter of Pharaoh came down to the river to bathe; and God sent her to the very spot where little Moses lay crying in his basket.



THE DAUGHTER OF PHARAOH CAME DOWN TO THE RIVER TO BATHE.

THE DAUGHTER OF PHARAOH CAME DOWN TO THE RIVER TO BATHE.

The Princess felt very sorry for the little baby, and guessed it must belong to one of the poor Jews who were ordered to throw their boys into the river. So she told her maids to take up the babe; and just as they did so,

little Miriam, who was not more than twelve years old, came up to see what would happen to her little brother.

When she saw the Princess was so kind, she offered, like a wise little girl, to fetch a nurse for him; and when the princess gave her permission, Miriam ran to Moses, own dear mother; and she was allowed to take care of him, to bring him up for the princess, who loved him so much that she called him her son.

We are told in the Epistle to the Hebrews, that it was "by faith" that Moses' parents saved his life! Because they trusted God to do for them what they could not do for themselves!

XLI. The Rod of God

Perhaps when you have thought of little Moses in the bulrushes, you have wondered what became of him when he grew up to be a man?

Well, at first when he was in Pharaoh's Palace, he was given hard lessons to learn, like any of us. But he seems to have been very clever and very industrious, for soon he became learned in all the arts of the Egyptians, and was mighty in word and in deed.

Though he was brought up so grandly in a palace, he did not forget that he was a Jew, one of the Children of Israel. He was very sorry to see his relations so cruelly treated, and sometimes he would walk down to the part of the town where the Jews lived, and would look at them as they toiled at the hard work which Pharaoh gave them to do.

One day Moses saw one of the Egyptians being very unkind to a Jew, and he ran to them and defended the Jew, and killed the Egyptian and hid

him in the sand; he thought the Jews would understand that God was going to send him to deliver them.

But the next day when he wished to settle a quarrel between two of the Children of Israel, they did not like it, and asked him if he was going to kill them as he did the Egyptian yesterday?

Then Moses was frightened, and left Pharaoh's beautiful palace, and all the splendour that he had enjoyed all his life, and went away quite far from Egypt for forty years! Here he was married and had two sons, and he kept his father-in-law's flocks, and lived very happily.

At length, when he was watching the sheep one day near to a mountain, the angel of God appeared to him in a flame of fire, out of the midst of a bush. Moses thought the sight so wonderful that he came closer to look at it, and then God called to him out of the burning bush and told him not to come near, as God Himself was there, and the place was very holy.

And the Lord said, what will comfort every one of us to remember, if we are in any trouble or sorrow, "I have surely seen the affliction of My people which are in Egypt, and have heard their cry by reason of their taskmasters; for I know their sorrows; and am come down to deliver them out of the hands of the Egyptians. Come now therefore, and I will send you to Pharaoh, that you may bring forth My people out of Egypt."

But at first Moses was very much afraid that the Children of Israel would not trust him, and he almost wanted God to send some other messenger who would do the work better.

But God was very patient with Moses; He kept on assuring him that He would help him in every difficulty, "Certainly I will be with thee," He said.

At last Moses told the Lord that the people would say that he had not seen God at all; and then the Lord asked him what it was which he held in his hand?

So Moses said it was a rod. Then God told him to throw it on the ground, and in a moment the rod had turned into a serpent!

Then God told him not to be afraid of it, but to catch it by its tail; and the serpent turned back into a rod in his hand.

So God told him to take that rod in his hand when he went to Egypt, for He would work signs with it for him.

Moses was still afraid, and then God allowed him to have his brother Aaron with him, that they might do God's wonderful signs together, and help each other.

At length Moses accomplished his journey to the land of the Pyramids, which it is probable the poor Jews were helping to build at that very time; and Moses stood before Pharaoh and gave him God's message "Let My people go that they may serve Me!"

But Pharaoh was not willing to understand that message. He saw those thousands of slaves, who were busy building his cities and his tombs, and he would not believe that there was anyone strong enough to deliver them from his powerful hand. So he said scornfully, "Who is the Lord, that I should obey His voice?"

XLII. Pharaoh's Refusal

So Moses and Aaron stood before Pharaoh and gave him God's message—

"Thus saith the Lord: Israel is My son, even My first-born . . . and I say unto thee, Let My son go that he may serve Me; and if thou refuse to let him go, behold I will slay thy son, even thy first-born."

Pharaoh was very angry. He did not love the great and holy God who made heaven and earth; but served his own gods made of wood and stone, who could not speak or move.

And he said scornfully, "Who is the Lord that I should obey His voice?"

So Moses did as the Lord had commanded him to do. He told Aaron, his brother, to take the Rod of God, which God had given him to do wonders with, and to cast it down on the ground in front of Pharaoh and his servants.

And when Aaron cast it down, the rod turned into a serpent!

So Pharaoh called his wise men and sorcerers to see what they could do. They were used to playing with snakes, and teaching them tricks; and when they threw down their rods, they also turned into serpents. But such a wonderful thing happened then—Aaron's rod swallowed up all their rods! That was a thing they could not do!

But Pharaoh's heart was hardened, and he would not let the Children of Israel go.

So God sent some dreadful plagues on the land of Egypt. He turned all their water into blood; He sent frogs over the land, which came into their houses and got up on to their beds; He sent a great darkness over all the land in the day-time, so that the Egyptians could not find their way about, and many more things which I have not space to tell you.

For many days Moses had been trying to persuade Pharaoh to let the Children of Israel go out of his land; and though God had sent great and dreadful plagues to warn the Egyptians that they must obey Him, yet Pharaoh would not listen.

At last, God sent Moses to him again and told him that if he would not let His people go, God would send His destroying angel through the land, and the first-born of every man and beast must die! And there would be most dreadful sorrow through all the land of Egypt.

XLIII. The Passover

The Easter full moon was shining down in all its white glory on the land of Egypt, more than three thousand years ago.

It was the last night that the Children of Israel were to stay in Egypt! To-morrow they would be free.

For that night, at midnight, the destroying angel would pass through the land of Egypt, to kill all the first-born of the Egyptians; and there would not be one house where there was not one dead.

Perhaps you think to yourselves, children, "But would the first-born of the Israelites die too? How would the destroying angel know which were Egyptians, and which were the Children of Israel?"

Ah! God had foreseen how to prevent that! He had not let plagues touch the houses of His own people!

He told Moses that all who wished to be safe on that dreadful night, must take a lamb, and when they had killed it, they must put its blood in a basin, and sprinkle the blood on their houses.

God told them to take a bunch of hyssop, and to sprinkle the top of the doorway and the side posts with blood; and He promised that when He saw the blood He would pass over that house, and not allow the destroying angel to enter.

That was why it was called The Lord's Passover.

And when God saw the blood of the Lamb, He looked forward to the time when His own dear Son would be the Lamb of God which taketh away

the sin of the world.

Do you not think, children, that those Israelites made sure that the blood was sprinkled on their house? Can you not Picture them running outside to look before they shut themselves inside the door? And can you not almost hear them saying, "Yes, there is the blood of the Lamb! Now we are safe!" And so hurry inside again, and stay there until the morning, as they were commanded.

And does not this question come home to your heart and mine to-day? Is the blood of the Lamb of God sprinkled on my heart? Am I safe from the punishment of my sins because Jesus died for me?

If so, children, we may rest secure, and go out rejoicing on our journey towards the Promised Land in heaven.

* * * * *

God told them also to take the flesh of the lamb and to roast it at the fire, and all who were in the house were to eat the Passover Supper. It was a night to be remembered for ever, when the Lord delivered His people out of Egypt! And we, too, may say—

"Christ our Passover is sacrificed for us, therefore let us keep the feast!"

XLIV. Bread from Heaven

So the Israelites left the Red Sea behind, and they went three days' journey into the wilderness, and found no water for them to drink.

At length they came to a place called Marah, where to their joy they found some water. But when they came to taste it, the water was so bitter that they could not drink it.

Then the people were very very angry with Moses, and blamed him very much.

So Moses cried to the Lord; and the Lord shewed him a tree, which when he had cast into the waters they were made sweet and nice, and the people could drink.

Soon after this the great company had eaten up all the bread they had brought out of Egypt, and there were no shops to buy anything at, nor any corn growing in the wilderness.

Here was a new trouble, so the people began to scold Moses and Aaron again, saying they wished they had stayed in Egypt after all.

They forgot all about the cruel taskmasters, and the bricks, and their slavery; and they told Moses he had brought them into the wilderness to kill them with hunger! How soon they had forgotten all that God had done for them, and how they had walked through the midst of the sea on dry land!

God was very grieved when He heard their murmurings; but He promised Moses that He would rain down bread from heaven for them to eat.

So that evening the Lord sent a number of little birds, called quails, for the people to eat, and they satisfied their hunger; and in the morning He sent them the bread from heaven which He had promised.

Perhaps you will say, children, "Loaves from heaven?" I daresay the Israelites thought the same, and wondered as you do.

So in the morning when they went out of their tents, the dew laid on the ground, and when the dew was gone, the whole ground was covered with little white seeds. And the Children of Israel called it Manna.

The Lord told them this was bread from heaven, and that they were to gather a measure—called an omer—full for each person, which would make them enough bread for the whole day.

On the day before the Sabbath, they were told to gather two omers full for every person, and to make it into cakes ready for the Sabbath day.

The taste of the cakes was like wafers made with honey.

And now, children, here comes a very sweet little lesson for you and for me.

Jesus is the true Bread from heaven, and every day, if we want to grow strong, and brave, and good, we should—before we begin the work, or play, or school of our day—kneel down and ask God to give us a sight of Jesus, and to let us taste the sweetness of His love. This will be our Bread from Heaven!

But soon came another difficulty. As the great company moved on their journey, they left the water which God had made sweet far behind them; and very soon they were thirsty again, and there was no water to drink!

They forgot all about the Manna and the sweetened water at Marah; and they went and scolded Moses again.

So God told Moses to go to the Rock in Horeb, and to strike it with his Rod, and water would flow out of it for the people to drink.

Moses did exactly as God told him, and the water flowed from the Rock, and so the People drank and were no longer thirsty.

XLV. The Tabernacle in the Wilderness

The children of Israel had been delivered from the bondage of the Egyptians, God had led them in the Wilderness by His pillar of cloud by day, and His pillar of fire by night; He had given them His Holy Law, which we call the Ten Commandments; and now God longed that the people should be brought near to Himself, and that He should be able to dwell among them.

So while Moses was up on the mountain alone with God, God told him to make tent or tabernacle where the people could bring their sacrifices, and where they might worship Him.

So the first thing Moses had to do was to tell the people that if they had willing hearts, they were to bring gold and silver and brass; and blue and purple and scarlet and fine linen; and shittim wood; and oil for light; and precious stones and spices; all these for an offering to the Lord, to be used for setting up the Tabernacle.



GIFTS FOR THE TABERNACLE.

GIFTS FOR THE TABERNACLE.

And then within the Tabernacle there were to be some very holy things.

It was divided into two parts. One part was called the Holy Place, and the other the Holiest of all.

In this Holiest place of all there was only one thing to be put, and that was an Ark with the Angels (called Cherubims), shadowing the Mercy Seat above it.

In this Ark, or chest, God told Moses to put the slabs of stone with the Commandments written upon it; and this reminds us of those words, "Yea,

Thy law is within my heart."

And then, resting on the top of the Ark, or chest, was the Mercy Seat, where the blood of the Lamb was sprinkled, and where God's glory would shine from day to day, as He talked with Moses from above the Mercy Seat.

Then in the other part of the Tabernacle, called the Holy place, there were to be three things. An Altar of Incense, overlaid with gold; the Table of Shewbread, where fresh loaves were to be put daily; and opposite to that, was the Golden Candlestick, all of gold, for the light.

God chose Bezaleel, the grandson of Hur, and filled him with wisdom to make all the wonderful things of the Tabernacle, according to the pattern God had given Moses, and to teach other wise-hearted men to help him in this holy work.

Surrounding the Tabernacle was a fence made with boards and curtains.

Every part of the Tabernacle was to be made so that it might be taken down, and carried from place to place, and put up again when the camp rested.

Only the priests might enter that enclosure hung with curtains. As the people looked into it from the doorway, or looked down upon it from the hillside above it, the first thing that they would see shining out in the light of the sun was the Brazen Altar, or Altar of Burnt Offering.



HERE THE PRIESTS OFFERED UP THE SACRIFICES.

HERE THE PRIESTS OFFERED UP THE SACRIFICES.

Here the Priests offered up the sacrifices which were brought by the people, and God accepted them for the sake of Jesus, His Holy Son. For, children, we cannot draw near to God to worship Him, without the perfect sacrifice of Jesus Christ our Lord, who is "the Lamb of God that taketh away the sin of the world."

Then there was the Laver of Brass, at which the Priests washed before they went into the Tabernacle.

I cannot tell you, children, all that this wonderful Tabernacle means, but some day you will be able to understand how it all foreshadowed the loving life, and glorious work, of our blessed Lord and Saviour Jesus Christ.

* * * * *

So when the Tabernacle was finished, "then a cloud covered the tent of the congregation, and the glory of the Lord filled the Tabernacle."

XLVI. Breaking God's Law

So God told Moses to lead the Children of Israel to a mountain called Sinai, and there He commanded all the congregation to wait while He gave them His Holy Law.

Moses went up to the top of the mountain to meet God, and to hear Him speak, and the people waited in the plains below.

But before God began to give His law to the people, He sent Moses down again to them to warn them once more not to come near the mountain; and even Moses, who was God's faithful servant, felt that the sight was very terrible, when he drew near to the thick darkness where God was.

God had many things to say to Moses, and many instructions to give him about making the beautiful Tabernacle, where they were to worship Him; so that he was up in the mountains a very long time—forty days and forty nights—and by and by the people began to get tired of waiting.



THE GLORY OF GOD.

They began to distrust God, and people soon get disobedient who distrust God! Then they said to Aaron, "Make us gods to carry before us, for as for this Moses, we do not know what has become of him."

I think Aaron was very sorry that the people were so foolish and so wicked. But he did as the people asked him. He made them a golden calf for them to worship, and allowed them to play round it.

Just as they were shouting and dancing and feasting, Moses began to come down from talking with God.

He held in his hand two pieces or slabs of stone on which God Himself had written His Holy Law—those ten Commandments which we often hear read, and which begin with "I am the Lord thy God which brought thee out of the Land of Egypt, out of the house of bondage, thou shalt have no other gods before ME."

Moses was carrying these two slabs of stone, and he and his servant Joshua (who I think had waited somewhere on the mountain while Moses talked with God) came down once more towards the camp. But when they had got within sight of it, they heard the sound of shouting and singing.

Then Moses looked down over the edge of the mountain, and he saw the golden calf set up, and the people worshipping it; and he was so grieved and angry that he cast down the two slabs of stone, which had been made by God, and written on by God, right out of his hand down the steep mountain side, and they were broken all to pieces!

Then Moses and Joshua hastened down, and Moses stopped the people in their worship of the golden calf. He cast it into the fire and burnt it, and was very angry with Aaron and the people.

Then he went to the Lord, and told Him all about it, confessing the great sin of the people, and asking Him to forgive it.

God is very pitiful and of tender mercy; and though He had to punish the people for their sin by sending a plague among them, yet He did forgive them, and He told Moses to lead the people forward again, and to make two fresh slabs of stone, and told him to write His law upon them over again.

How often we find in our daily lives, children, that when we mean to be very good, after all, we do not keep to what we had intended to do.

The only way is for us to ask God to write His Holy Law in our hearts every day, and to beg Him to keep us from doing what would displease Him. If we trust in our own strength we shall be sure to fail; but if we look to Him and truly seek to please Him, He will help us to become more and more like the Lord Jesus.

And when we know that we have failed in anything, let us not wait a single moment, but lift our hearts to our Father in heaven, and ask Him, for Jesus' sake, to wash away our sin and make us pure and white again in the precious Blood of Jesus, the Lamb of God.

XLVII. A Great Victory

Soon after the smiting of the Rock, out of which God made water to flow for the people's thirst, another difficulty came.

As the great company of the Children of Israel travelled on, some enemies, called, Amalekites, came out against them, and tried to conquer them.

So Moses called Joshua and told him to choose men who could fight, to go against the Amalekites; and that he would go to-morrow to the top of the hill with the Rod of God in his hand.

So Joshua did as Moses had said to him, and fought with Amalek; and Moses and Aaron and Hur went up to the top of the hill.

So Moses stretched out his hand with the Rod of God in it, and then the Children of Israel prevailed and conquered, but when he let down his hand, Amalek prevailed.

But poor Moses got very weary, and his hands seemed very heavy, so that he could not hold them up any longer!

But Aaron and Hur thought of a very good plan. They took a large stone for Moses to sit on, and they stood by him and held up his hands, one on each side, and his hands were steady till the sun went down.

And Joshua had a great victory over Amalek, because God fought for them.

And God told Moses to write it down in a book, and tell Joshua about it, that He would utterly destroy the Amalekites.

We read afterwards in Deuteronomy xxv. 17, that God had been specially angry with the Amalekites because they had attacked the Israelites when they were faint and weary, and had smitten the hindmost and weak ones in the camp instead of fighting bravely with the strong.

It seems to me that we may take this first battle of the Israelites as a sort of picture of Satan's temptations and buffetings.

He attacks us where we are weakest. He perhaps tells us that God has forgotten us for a little while, that we are like those weaker Israelites in the camp, who were particularly exposed to the enemy!

Then what must we do, when we feel Satan is too strong for us?

We must, like Joshua, resist with all the fighting power at our disposal; and like Moses we must take the Rod of God—the rod of faith and prayer—and go up on the hill top and get nearer God!

Do you wonder what the hill top is for us?

It is kneeling in our room and asking Him to help us.

It is looking up with our hearts, and saying one word of faith to Jesus!

And when they had gained that great victory over Amalek, Moses built an altar to God, and offered a sacrifice, and he called the name of it—

"Jehovah-Nissi," which means "The Lord our Banner!"

Here is a hymn which has comforted and cheered numbers of people who have found Satan—like Amalek—very strong!

Why should I fear the darkest hour,
Or tremble at the Tempter's power?
Jesus vouchsafes to be my Tower!

Though hot the fight, why quit the field?
Why must I either fly or yield,
Since Jesus is my mighty shield?

I know not what may soon betide,
Or how my wants shall be supplied;
But Jesus knows, and will provide.

Though sin would fill me with distress,
The Throne of Grace I dare address,
Since Jesus is my righteousness.

Though faint my prayers and cold my love,
My steadfast hope shall not remove,
While Jesus intercedes above.

Against me earth and hell combine:
But on my side is power divine:
Jesus is all, and He is mine!

XLVIII. Caleb's Daughter

The old man whom you see in this picture is Caleb, one of the two faithful spies who brought a good report of the land of Canaan.

So when after forty years, the land was divided among the people, Joshua blessed Caleb and gave him Hebron or Kirjath Arba: and Caleb drove out from it three giants, and he made his home there.

There were still many enemies round him, so Caleb sent his soldiers to fight against Kirjath Sepher, and promised that the man who took the city should have his daughter Achsah for his wife.

So Othniel the son of Kenaz was the successful one. At length the wedding day came. When Achsah was starting for her husband's home, she begged Othniel to ask her father to give her a field as a wedding present.



HE GAVE HER THE UPPER SPRINGS AND THE NETHER SPRINGS.

HE GAVE HER THE UPPER SPRINGS AND THE NETHER SPRINGS.

Caleb seems to have agreed to this; but Achsah knew he was rich as well as loving; so she alighted off her ass, and ran to his side, "Give me a blessing!" she said. "You have given me a south land—give me also springs of water!"

And he gave her the upper springs and the nether springs.

* * * * *

Jesus says to us to-day, "How much more shall your Father which is in heaven, give the Holy Spirit to them that ask Him."

XLIX. The First King

So the child Samuel grew up and became a prophet of the Lord, and he judged the people and helped them in all their difficulties, by encouraging them to seek God and trust in Him.

But the Children of Israel often turned back from the Lord and followed their own ways, even making idols for themselves like the Canaanites had.

This grieved Samuel very much, because he knew that it would make God very angry with them.

At length Samuel was getting to be an old man, and the people got tired of being judged by his sons, who were not very good and faithful young men, and they asked Samuel to make a king to rule them, and go to war with them as they saw other nations do.

This was the greatest grief of all to Samuel, because the Lord was their King! But nothing that he could say would turn them from their wish to have a king whom they could see, and who would lead them to battle against their enemies.

The Lord told Samuel that he could do as the people asked; but that in choosing an earthly king they had rejected the Lord, who had brought them up out of the land of Egypt, and delivered them from all their foes.

There was at this time a man of the tribe of Benjamin whose name was Saul. He was a very handsome young man, and was so tall that he was head and shoulders above everyone else. His father's name was Kish.

One day, the asses belonging to Kish strayed away and got lost, and Saul and his servant went a very long way to seek for them.

They searched for a long time, but could not find them. At last, the servant suggested that they should go to the prophet who lived near the place to which they had travelled, for he thought perhaps he might tell them where to find the asses.

So they came to the city where Samuel the prophet lived, and when they made enquiries, they found that Samuel was going to offer a sacrifice there that very day.

Now the Lord had told Samuel that He would bring the young man who was to be king to him, that he might anoint him.

So Samuel met Saul and invited him to dinner, and told him that he wanted to speak to him presently, and that he should go back to-morrow. "And as for the asses," he said, "that were lost three days ago, they are found!"

So when they had eaten their meal, Samuel and Saul went on the housetop and Samuel talked with him for a long time; and early the next morning Samuel took a vial of oil and poured it on Saul's head, and told him he was anointed to be King over God's inheritance.

He told him also that he was to go to Gilgal and wait there seven days, until he came down to him to offer a sacrifice to the Lord.

But now, children, we come to Saul's first disobedience. Saul waited seven days, but he forgot that God's prophet had said "wait seven days, even till I come to offer the sacrifice," and when Samuel delayed to come for a few hours, Saul took upon himself to offer the sacrifice.

Then Samuel came! And Saul hurried out to meet him. But Samuel drew back from his greeting, and told him he had been very disobedient, and that the Lord would choose someone else to be the king; one who would keep God's commandments and love Him with all his heart!

So Samuel went back to Gilgal, and Saul went to fight against the Philistines.

* * * * *

By and by God sent another message to Saul by Samuel the prophet, and this was the message: "Thus saith the Lord of Hosts, I remember what Amalek did to Israel . . . when he came up from Egypt, now go and smite Amalek, and utterly destroy all that they have, and spare them not."

So Saul went to fight against Amalek and conquered them; but again he was disobedient. He saved the king and did not kill him as he had been commanded, and he also saved all the best of the sheep and oxen.

Then the Lord said to Samuel, "It repenteth Me that I have made Saul king, for he hath not kept My commandments."

And it grieved Samuel, and he cried unto the Lord all that night.

And when Samuel rose early in the morning to meet Saul, the king hurried to him and told him he had done all that the Lord had told him to do!

But Samuel stopped him. "What is the meaning of this bleating of sheep that I hear, then?" he asked.

And Saul said, "The people saved the best to sacrifice to God!"

And Samuel said, "Do you think that the Lord has as much pleasure in sacrifice as in obeying the voice of the Lord? Behold, to obey is better than sacrifice, and to hearken than the fat of rams. Because thou hast rejected the word of the Lord, He hath also rejected thee from being king."

And as Samuel sorrowfully turned away, he knew that he should never see Saul's face again.

This is a very sad and solemn story, children.

Let us all be aware of little disobediences, lest they should grow into greater ones.

God will dwell in the humble and contrite heart, which trembles at his word. He will give grace to the lowly.

Let us pray, as David did in Psalm cxix., "With my whole heart have I sought Thee: O let me not wander from Thy commandments!"

And then this promise shall be ours: "He that doeth the will of God abideth for ever!"

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